DAILY
COLUMBIA SPECTATOR
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2026

HOMECOMING

Homecoming past to present

Frames of the game, student spirit, and more—look back at Homecoming weekend through Spectator's archive.

BY AUDREA CHEN
Photo Editor

Since the first Homecoming celebration in 1948, Homecoming weekend has remained a crucial part of the Columbia experience. From tailgates, to picnics, to parties, and more, student excitement around the event builds against the backdrop of a busy midterms season. As students and alumni alike prepare for this weekend, look at past Homecoming weekends, through Spectator.

audrea.chen
@columbiaspectator.com

PHOTO BY DAVID FONDILLER

Oct. 13, 1984: Columbia's 1934 Rose Bowl team was honored at the 1984 Homecoming game against Princeton. The Lions ultimately lost the game, 38-8.

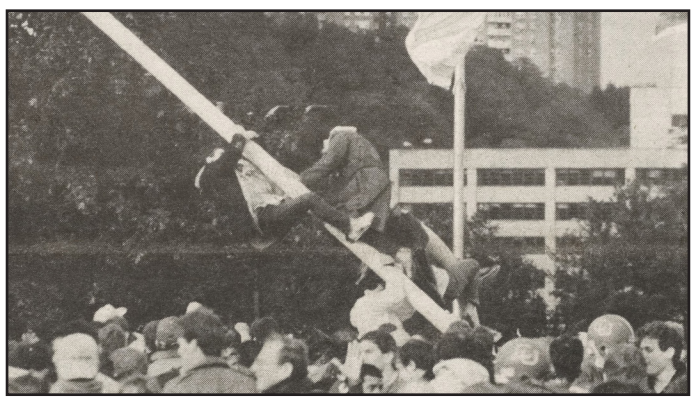


PHOTO BY ED BAILEY

Oct. 8, 1988: Columbia snapped a NCAA Division I record 44-game losing streak during a legendary game against Princeton. The Lions won 16-13, and students celebrated the end of the drought by storming the field.

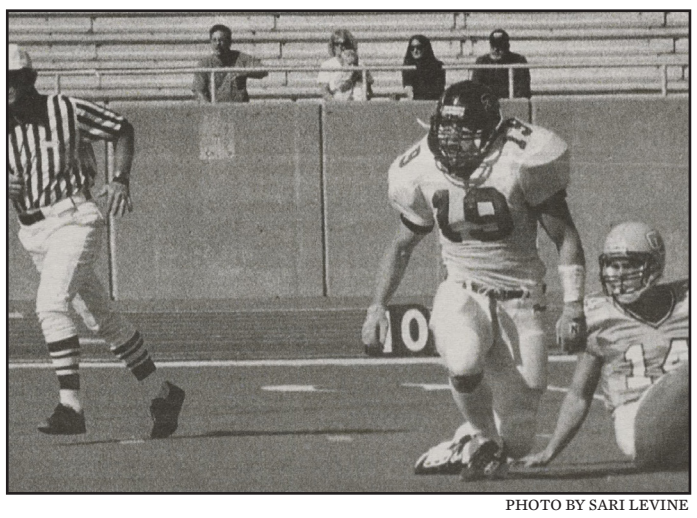


PHOTO BY SARI LEVINE

Oct. 16, 1999: Columbia's senior quarterback at the time, Mike Glynn, pictured after being leveled by Penn's defense.

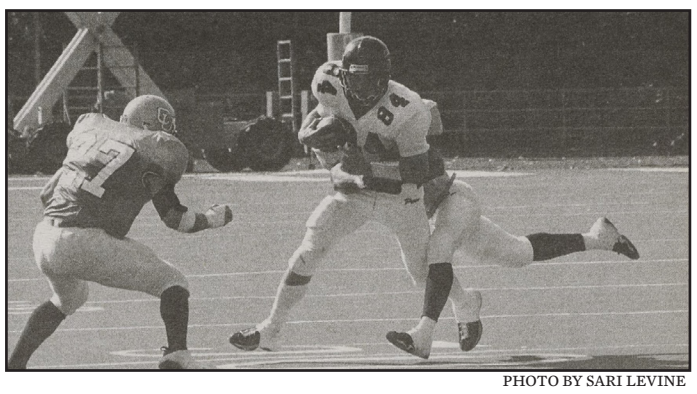
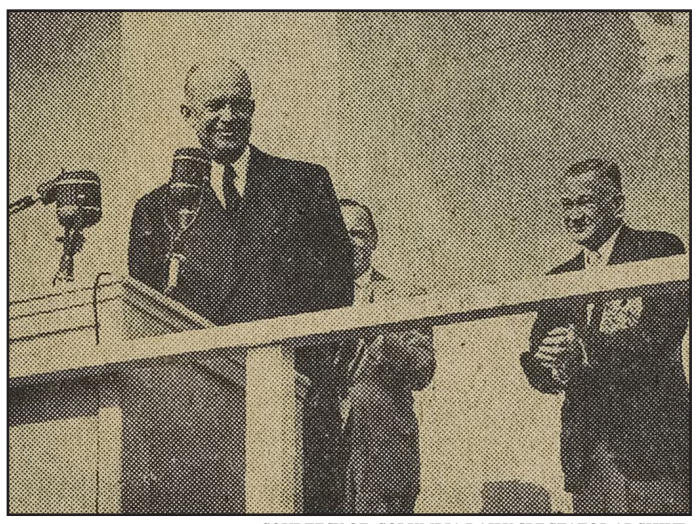


PHOTO BY SARI LEVINE

Oct. 16, 1999: Columbia and Penn went head to head during the 1999 Homecoming game. Penn ultimately trounced Columbia, winning 41-17.

PHOTO BY PAT HOLDER

Oct. 21, 2000: Over 9,000 students packed Wien Stadium for the Homecoming game against Dartmouth, where Columbia prevailed 49-21.



COURTESY OF COLUMBIA DAILY SPECTATOR ARCHIVE

Oct. 12, 1948: Following his inauguration as the 13th University president in October 1948, President Dwight Eisenhower addressed Columbia alumni at a picnic lunch during the first Homecoming weekend, starting in a decades-long tradition.

COURTESY OF COLUMBIA DAILY SPECTATOR ARCHIVE

Oct. 8, 1956: Legendary football coach Lou Little speaking to the team during practice. Little was the longest-tenured and winningest coach in Columbia football history.

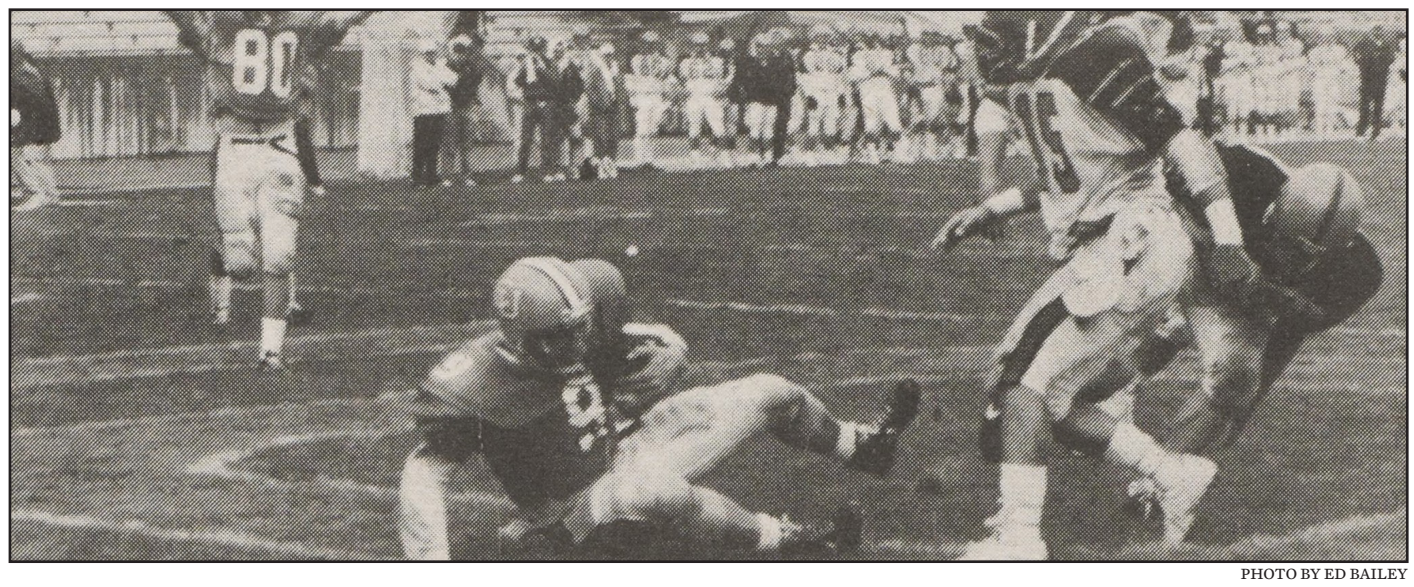


PHOTO BY ED BAILEY

Oct. 8, 1988: Moments from the field during the 1988 Homecoming game

PHOTO BY SHAWN CHOY

Oct. 21, 2000: The now-defunct Columbia Marching Band during the 2000 Homecoming game against Dartmouth

PHOTO BY LISA LEWIS

Oct. 4, 2008: The Lions attempted a fake field goal play during the 2008 Homecoming game against Princeton.

PHOTO BY ALYSON GOULDEN

Oct. 20, 2012: Columbia's offense was pummeled by Dartmouth during the 2012 Homecoming game, which marked the 12th straight Homecoming loss.

PHOTO BY ESMERALDA PAREDES

Oct. 18, 2025: The 2025 Homecoming defeat marked Columbia's fourth consecutive loss.

PHOTO BY GIADA ROBINSON

Oct. 18, 2025: Fans filled Wien Stadium during the 2025 Homecoming game. Columbia lost to Penn 35-21.

Head coach Jon Poppe is on year 3—and ready for another championship

BY NICHOLAS FINK
& EVAN VAN BRUNT
Columbia Daily Spectator

SAUMYA CHAUDRY / ILLUSTRATIONS EDITOR

POPPE'S PROCESS | After winning the Ivy League in his first season, Poppe is in the hunt again.

In his third season at the helm, football head coach Jon Poppe hopes that he has not changed.

Since returning to the program where he previously served as the defensive back coach and recruiting coordinator from 2015 to 2017, Poppe has experienced the highest of highs—as well as the all-too-familiar lows—of Columbia football.

In 2024, his first season back in Morningside Heights and only his second-ever as a head coach, Poppe led the Lions to an improbable, three-way tie Ivy League title. He shook off 63 years of demons, delivering rare joy to a school that once experienced the longest-ever losing streak in college football history.

A year later, the Light Blue finished last in the Ancient Eight, with its only conference win coming in the last game of the season. Through these two years, Poppe has never let himself or his players get too high or too low. Now, midway through the 2026 season, Poppe and the Lions find themselves with a young roster—largely recruited by Poppe himself—and another chance to make a run at the championship.

"I'm excited about the growth that we're building, the type of program we're building," he said in an interview with Spectator. "I really love what we've brought in here in terms of people, in terms of true competitive student athletes that are maximizing every minute they have every single day."

To get there, however, Poppe recognizes that the Lions will need to improve their execution.

In the Light Blue's Ivy League opener against Princeton, missed opportunities sunk its chance at victory. Despite making it into the red zone five times, Poppe's squad managed only one touchdown, leaving points on the field in a game that could have been close, but instead turned into a 35-7 blowout.

In all, the Light Blue went 0-4 on fourth-down attempts and is 0-9 on the season, raising questions about the aggressiveness of the Lions' playcalling. Poppe said that responsibility for the decisions "falls squarely on my shoulders."

"Maybe it is taking points sometimes and giving Hugo the opportunity that he's earned to kick field goals," he said. "What does that do to the game? What does that do to the confidence of your team? And that's something as we move forward that I'm struggling to reflect upon."

But the team's fourth-down struggles have broader implications in different contexts beyond efficiency in the red zone. Seven of nine turnovers on downs occurred when the Lions were not in the red zone. While Poppe's aggression is often viewed with respect by modern football crowds, a novice offensive line hinders security in making those fourth down plays.

The Light Blue's trench is made up of two sophomores and a first-year, adding difficulty for the offense's capabilities against a fourth-down blitz. Still, Poppe remains confident in the line's potential to create a pocket.

"We got to be sharper in our scheme in terms of our run blocking in those short yardage situations, and how teams are loading the box and attacking our gaps. And that's been the growing thing for us as you look at our offensive line," Poppe said about the learning front five. "There are some growing pains that we don't want, but they exist."

These pains also exist on the other side of the ball, as Columbia's rushing defense has allowed the second-most rushing yards and touchdowns across the Ancient Eight this season. Despite these defensive shortcomings, Poppe still sees a path to guide the defense in the right direction.

"I have to get them playing faster and more physical and create more distortion and attack the run game, and that's what I anticipate after seeing a pretty good week of practice here," the head coach said.

Even with his attention to the team's finer details, Poppe maintains full faith in his coaching staff to act as mentors for their respective units, illustrating a new culture of confidence.

This trust in the Lions and their staff grants Poppe new opportunities to make the most of their weapons, work with the rookies, and direct his mind toward the program's future.

In the 2026 season, a consistent star for the Light Blue's offense has been senior running back Griffin Johnson. The rusher has carried for 486 yards so far—the third most in the Ivy League. Poppe, aware of his running back's ability, created dual-threat opportunities for Johnson. He received for 102 yards, with his longest catch being 22 yards.

"Anyone that wants to see the type of character we're trying to build here, or a program we're trying to build through character, you just look at Griff," Poppe remarked about Johnson.

Poppe's vision is defined by a culture built around character, both on and off the gridiron. To execute this concept, the head coach depends on his veteran players to steer the ship. Between experienced players advising the rookies in their respective rooms to veterans leading pre-season camps, the Lions have established team chemistry with the goal of creating an "elite passing offense."

Poppe emphasized that to get back atop the Ancient Eight, his players will need to follow the habits and work ethic of the 2024 squad.

"What level of detail, and what level of commitment it really takes to win more often than lose, and how small these margins can be," he said.

Along with a rise in solidarity and trust, this season has seen Poppe increasingly rely on first-year players. Rookies like Bryce Coleman, Gavin Barth, Rocco Costello, and CJ Willingham have made a major impact on the field, with Poppe's own recruiting classes beginning to dominate play for the Lions. But the head coach made it clear that these opportunities were earned, not handed freely.

"It shows you have the opportunity to compete to play right away, and that's all young people, in my opinion, want, is a true opportunity," Poppe said. "They've been awesome."

What has been a season of transformation for Poppe's unit carries both reflections on past mistakes and plans for the future. But at the end of the day, the head coach stays focused on the present task at hand: to bring an Ivy League title back to Morningside Heights.

With Dartmouth coming round the bend, Poppe has his sights set only on a Homecoming victory over the Big Green.

nicholas.fink
@columbiaspectator.com

evan.vanbrunt
@columbiaspectator.com

How football captains Charlie Newton and Caleb Solomon are leading the Light Blue

BY EVAN VAN BRUNT
& AJAY BALAJE
Deputy Sports Editors

Football, now 4-1 on the season, finds itself in the thick of its Ivy League hunt, prowling into the forest to contend against Dartmouth.

At the forefront of this game, head coach Jon Poppe and his coaching staff assist in leading the Lions into battle. But behind the scenes, captains senior linebacker Charlie Newton and junior defensive back Caleb Solomon work on and off the field to rally the troops for a better season than last year.

Newton made a name for himself in high school as a multitool player, logging snaps at linebacker, wide receiver, cornerback, safety, and returner. In his senior season, he captained his team to its third conference championship in four years, catching for 887 yards and 13 touchdowns while also making 89 tackles on defense. Solomon similarly starred before arriving in Morningside Heights, entertaining offers from schools in the Football Bowl Subdivision before committing to Columbia.

Both players quickly settled into their roles with the Light Blue, notching significant game time in their first few seasons on campus. The pair broke out in the 2025 season, combining for 23 tackles in the Lions' first game and never looking back. Solomon and Newton would go on to combine for 135 tackles and two interceptions across the season, giving Columbia's defense reason to hope.

For Newton, captaining the team for his final collegiate season is special.

"It's an honor and a privilege to be named captain," Newton said. "We have a lot of great leaders on this team. I think we just try and do our best to keep the guys encouraged, keep them in the right headspace, and get this team where it needs to be."

Solomon may not have Newton's four years of experience, but his influence is tangible all the same. The Florida native is still growing into his role as a leader, but he does so with the full backing of his team.

"It's good knowing guys count on me to be able to do that, especially as a junior, and I'm willing to accept that challenge," Solomon said.

In their time as captains, Newton and Solomon have emphasized togetherness on the team, focusing on building a sense of camaraderie across the roster.

"Creating that brotherhood every day, creating that bond, I feel like that's the only way that we can be successful," Newton said. "I think we're just trying to, every day, foster that sense of community with each other and that sense of accountability and brotherhood."

Solomon agreed, noting the importance of leading from within rather than above the group.

"We're holding guys accountable on both sides of the ball, and also, guys are holding us as captains accountable as well, because we're all going on the field as one," Solomon added. "It's not a hierarchy at all."

Despite Solomon and Newton both being defensive players, neither captain shies away from leading on offense.

"We're not always connected to those guys as much," Solomon said. "But we also try to integrate both sides of the ball in our leadership."

But when occupied with defensive responsibilities, the captains rely on experienced players to help keep the team on track. Newton specifically highlighted senior quarterback Chase Goodwin, senior tight end Braden Dougherty, and senior offensive lineman Nik Winzer as crucial leaders to the offense.

"There's many of them, a lot of people that step up to make this team what it is," Solomon said.

The new changes in leadership don't end there. Defensive coordinator Ryan Osborn has stepped in this year as the new playcaller for the Lions, assisting the co-captains in leading the defense in the right direction.

"He's a coach that is going to push you harder than you've ever been pushed before. But he expects greatness out of each and every one of us on the field and off the field, and that's what you kind of need to grow yourself—not as a defense, but just as a player and as a person," Solomon said.

Newton also faced the unique challenge of leading the Lions without taking the field with the team. Usually Columbia's iron man, the senior captain unfortunately missed the first four games of the Light Blue's season due to an injury.

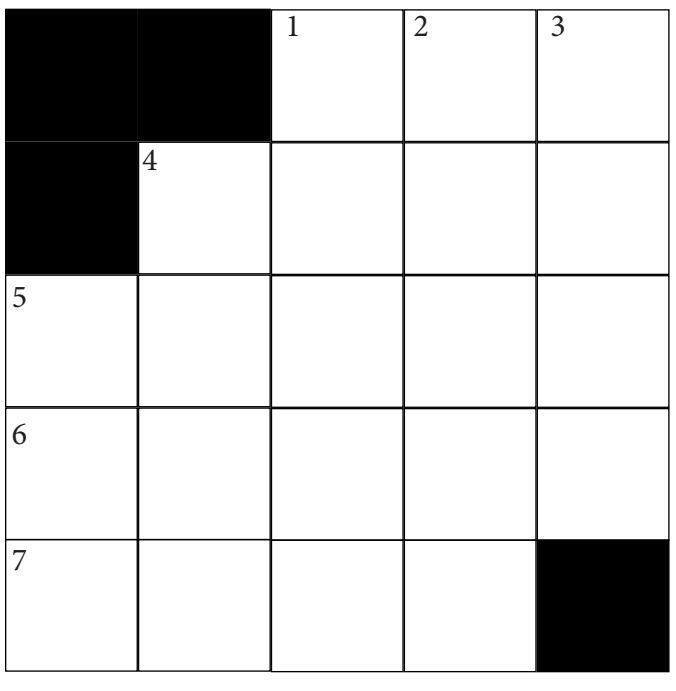
"As far as a leadership standpoint, I don't think it really impacts anything," Newton said. "It is obviously harder because you're not practicing in there, in the trenches with the guys, so it's harder to have that same day-to-day voice. But you know what? I'm at every practice and I'm doing everything with everyone, so really not much has changed on that front."

Despite the difficulties and changes of a new season, the co-captains continue to stand firm as the generals of the pride, looking to the future with hope and ambition.

"I'm really looking forward to seeing this team really develop into the team that we know we can be," Newton said. "We're just so motivated to make good on everything that we've done."

evan.vanbrunt
@columbiaspectator.com

ajay.balaje
@columbiaspectator.com



Hoco Mini

BY ANNIE HAN
Deputy Sports Editor

Across
1) Extra point in football
4) Sound that Roaree makes
5) Trendy pants this summer
6) Where to hop, in a Dr. Seuss book
7) Columbia University home stadium

Down
1) Head coach of Columbia football
2) Quarterback for the Pittsburgh Steelers
3) Illegal obstruction of opponent resulting in a 15-yard penalty
4) Important solid catalyst used in organic chemistry
5) The animal behind Doja Cat's viral song

To find the solution to this mini-crossword, scan here.

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CONTACT US
91 Claremont Avenue, Room 414
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Football has had a budding start to the season ahead of Homecoming

BY HOLDEN LOMBARDO & EVAN VAN BRUNT
Columbia Daily Spectator

Football opened the 2026 season hoping to return to form. After a thrilling start, the Lions look ahead to Homecoming as they ride the momentum of a winning record and explosive playmaking on both sides of the ball.

Only a year after the team's first conference title in 63 years, the Light Blue (4-1, 1-1 Ivy) took a significant step back in 2025, finishing last in the Ivy League amid injuries and a struggling offense. In head coach Jon Poppe's third season with the Lions, he looks to turn the team around.

"I really love what we've brought in here in terms of people," he said in an interview with Spectator. "I do truly believe it's gonna turn into some consistent winning seasons here."

LAFAYETTE COLLEGE

In the season opener against Lafayette College (2-4), the Lions exploded with a high-powered home performance. Senior quarterback Chase Goodwin bounced back from a season plagued by injury and inconsistent play, throwing for 367 yards and two touchdowns, while senior running back Griffin Johnson rushed for 124 yards in Columbia's overtime 40-34 win.

First-year wide receiver Bryce Coleman made an immediate splash, hauling in two touchdowns and 127 yards in a debut that earned him Ivy League Co-Rookie of the Week. But the Lions struggled to stop the rush, and the game came down to an overtime interception by sophomore defensive back MD Awe.

GEORGETOWN UNIVERSITY

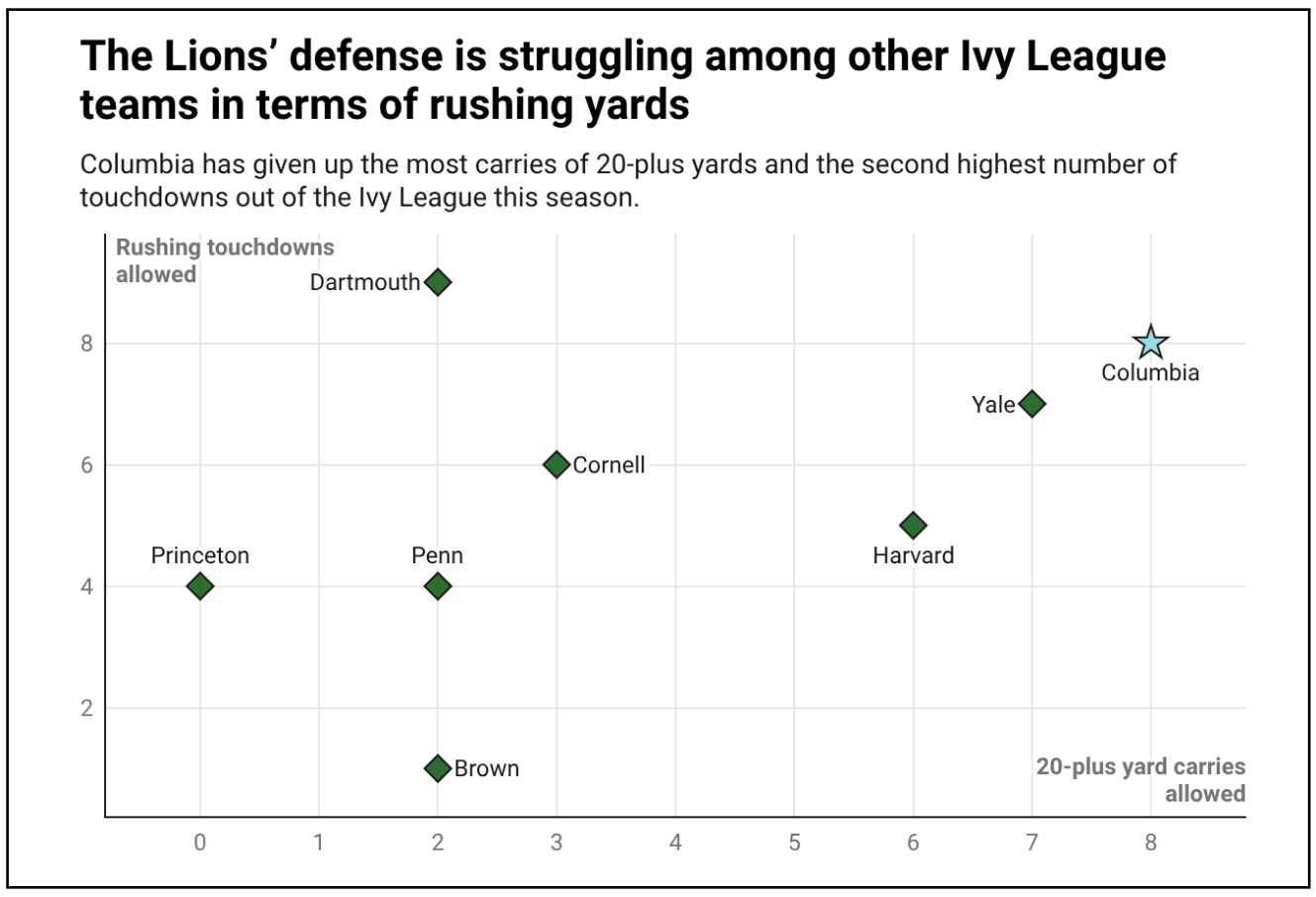
Next, Columbia traveled to Washington, D.C., to take on Georgetown University (2-4) in the Lou Little Cup. The Lions were able to make up for a lackluster offensive effort with a strong defensive stand that held Georgetown to less than 250 total yards of offense.

Despite a pair of interceptions from Goodwin, Johnson's strong play kept the Lions alive and sent them to their second straight overtime. Senior kicker Hugo Merry sealed the win 20-17 for the Light Blue as it improved to its first 2-0 record since 2022.

PRINCETON UNIVERSITY

The Lions returned home hoping to carry their momentum into the start of conference play against Princeton (4-1, 2-0 Ivy). Last season, the Tigers barely sealed the victory against the Light Blue, pulling ahead by one touchdown.

This game proved to be an entirely different story, as Columbia's defense found no answer for Princeton running back Kai Honda, who steamrolled the Lions for 219 yards and four touchdowns. Ultimately, Columbia's record fell to 2-1 after the 35-7 blowout, starting out on the wrong foot in conference play and in serious need of addressing the team's rush defense.



SITA VEMURI / SENIOR DATA VISUALIZATION REPORTER

MARIST UNIVERSITY

After the crushing loss to the Tigers, Columbia ventured to Marist University (4-3) for its last nonconference game. Sophomore defensive lineman Jonah Walker spearheaded the Lions' defense in the first half, blocking a field goal and forcing a strip-six. Down 28-21 entering the fourth quarter, the Lion offense finally shined, securing a 41-28 win with 20 unanswered points.

With only one interception, Goodwin put together a well-fought game, throwing for 277 yards and three touchdown passes to each of the core wide receivers. Junior wide receiver Hutch Crow led the signal caller's targets with 105 receiving yards, averaging 15 yards per reception.

PENN

The Lions then took on Penn (2-3, 0-2 Ivy) in Philadelphia to begin their consecutive conference play. While Columbia started the second quarter down 24-7, the team rallied a similar comeback to the one against Marist. The Light Blue prevailed 28-27 as the Quakers missed a game-winning field goal due to poor time management. This victory improved the Light Blue to a 4-1 start for the first time since the 2024 season.

Coleman showcased his talent, receiving for 90 yards with three touchdowns—his highest single-game score with Columbia. The Light Blue's defense also fired on all cylinders with four interceptions and a sack.

So far, Columbia has written a different story for itself, with Poppe holding the pen. The Lions' success has prevailed through the establishment of consistent offensive weapons for Goodwin. On the ground, Johnson, ranked third in Ivy League rushing yards, leads the running back room as a consistent rusher, setting an example for backups sophomore running back Michael Walters and first-year running back Brody McLaughlin.

In the air, Goodwin is spoiled for choice. Coleman, tied for first in receiving touchdowns, is the play caller's go-to guy for scoring opportunities, with roughly 23 percent of the receiver's receptions being touchdowns. Crow finds his role as short-yardage receiver for the Lions, sitting at 12.1 yards per reception. When in search of long distance, Goodwin turns to sophomore wide receiver Beckett Robinson, who is currently leading the Light Blue at 21 yards per reception.

Poppe attributed the recent success to consistency from the offensive core.

"It's been awesome, from a team standpoint, to have your offense be able to sustain drives to take some plays off the defense, right?" Poppe stated. "Whether it's through the air, through the ground game, I feel like our team is a complete and balanced one from an offensive perspective."

However, the Lion defense still remains a work in progress, with its main point of concern being the run defense, as the front seven rank second-to-last in the conference in rushing yards and touchdowns allowed. However, the secondary, fronted by Awe, remains a crucial defensive factor; Columbia is tied in the Ivy League for second in interceptions with six picks.

"You're always trying to stop the run or force them to throw, right? If you can prove you can stop the run, come the fourth quarter, usually it makes your life a little easier as a defense," Poppe said. "So, we've got to be ready to make sure we understand completely what we're trying to defend or limit. But the run game is always number one in my mind."

Looking to maintain its winning record, Columbia begins the conference stretch of play with a Homecoming standoff against Dartmouth. In its lead up to Homecoming, the Light Blue focuses on adapting to the other teams' style of play.

"Game planning is game planning, right?" Poppe said about the Lions' Homecoming strategy. "That's always the goal every week is to make sure we are putting our best players versus maybe their not-best players, and that's hopefully the difference."

holden.lambardo
@columbiaspectator.com

evan.vanbrunt
@columbiaspectator.com

Justin Townsend, CC '25, is on his third effort

BY CALEB LEE
Staff Writer

Patience runs out quickly at Scott Stadium. The home of the Virginia Cavaliers at the University of Virginia naturally demands excellence: Sweat beads and tempers flare when the team stumbles, squanders a lead, or falls short of expectations.

The Cavaliers (4-3), one year removed from their best season in 35 years, were routed 38-7 at Florida State University on Oct. 3, before returning home to first-half boos during a rain-soaked Oct. 10 battle against Syracuse University.

Among the players emerging from the rain that night was a man who has weathered tougher rooms: Justin Townsend, CC '25, a fifth-year defensive end and the all-time sack leader in Columbia history. He arrived in Charlottesville, Virginia, this year with a sociology degree from Columbia and one year of eligibility left, which he refused to leave on the table.

"The game isn't forever," Townsend said. "It's going to end at some point, and having an extra year of eligibility, I would regret not using it down the line. When I'm 30 or 40 years old, just wondering what would have happened if I'd played that extra year."

His logic sounds simple enough, but after his up-and-down journey through college football, the decision was anything but. Townsend arrived in Morningside Heights in 2021 as a high school running back and linebacker from Randolph, New Jersey, weighing 225 pounds and never having played defensive end before. Former head coach Al Bagnoli promptly changed that.

In high school, Townsend said, "At all times, I felt like I was the best player on the field—and then you get to college, where every single person was that player."

He didn't see a snap in his first fall, spending the season on the scout team instead. Nonetheless he capitalized on the opportunity, spending his time off the field training his body to fit the new position. Equally instrumental for Townsend's prowess was the locker room, which he treated with reverence, "able to learn from the older guys, and see how they approached their business every single day."

The apprenticeship paid off quickly: Townsend gained weight each year, standing at 255 pounds by 2023, and the accolades list grew with him. As a sophomore, he logged six sacks and earned second-team All-Ivy honors. In his junior year he followed with 7.5 sacks—tying him for the league lead—along with a pick six at Princeton, and Columbia football's defensive player of the year award.

Then came 2024, the season the Light Blue finally cashed in on the championship check it had been writing for years. The Lions finished 7-3, sharing the Ivy League title with Harvard and Dartmouth. It was Columbia's first championship since 1961.

Townsend, however, spent most of the run watching from the sidelines. An ACL injury ended his season after three starts.

"It just makes you appreciate every practice a lot more, every game a lot more, because it could get taken away from you at every moment," he said.

The injury, in a twist, bought him another year of eligibility, an opportunity he never thought about wasting. Head coach Jon Poppe says Townsend came back the same way he did during a play: He refused to stop. By the start of the 2025 season, he was ready to go.

"In terms of his knack for having a high motor, that was the biggest thing that made Justin so successful in college," Poppe said. "His ability to continue the play and not be deterred in terms of his first pass rush move not working, his second counter maybe not working. Sometimes those third efforts are really where his sacks showed up."

The numbers back up the praise. Townsend, a newly minted team captain, led the Ivy League in 2025 with 14 tackles for loss and finished second with 8.5 sacks, behind only Yale's defensive end Ezekiel Larry. In the season finale, a 29-12 win over Cornell, he logged 2.5 sacks and became Columbia's all-time sack record holder, finishing with 23 in total.

It was, for all intents and purposes, a glorious individual year, Townsend's self-described "best season of football," and a campaign that gave him renewed motivation to play.

"I was already nearing the end of my career as a senior when I got hurt, so going into that season I was definitely cautious—not cautious, but uncertain as to how I truly would come back," he said. "I feel like that was more of a feat for me, just being able to see that I could come back and play still at the highest level."

In mid-April, UVA, in the middle of rebuilding its pass rush after its two sack leaders left for NFL shots, signed him in his sixth and final year of eligibility. For Townsend, it was the realization of a long-held goal.

"My whole life, that was my dream: to play at a Power Four level," he said, "and having the ability to do so, I feel like I would make 12-year-old me extremely proud and happy."

So how has Townsend handled the leap to a program with a football-only dining hall? Well, the players are bigger.

"We have three practice fields. We have 30 coaches," he said. "There were maybe reasons why if you see a 6-foot-6 defensive end at the FCS level, why he's not playing at FBS level. Whereas here, you see a player of that size who also has extreme skill," he added, referring to the Football Championship Subdivision and Football Bowl Subdivision, respectively.

GIADA ROBINSON / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

NOT GIVING UP | With one year of eligibility left and an NFL dream still alive,

After feeling slightly overwhelmed during his first practice on an FBS team, where the pace was significantly faster, Townsend again drew on his mental strength, using a wide perspective to adjust and get accustomed to the speed.

"At the end of the day, it's still football," he said. "It's the same game I've played my whole life."

By his reckoning, the leap from high school to college was far tougher than the one from FCS to FBS. He also has familiar company in the defensive line room. Yale's Larry, the 2025 Ivy League sack leader, transferred to UVA as well, meaning the league's top two sack leaders from last year now share a locker room in Charlottesville.

For Townsend, football as he knows it will be over in December. The NFL draft process runs through April, and he'll be at UVA taking classes the whole time. The league has always been a goal of Townsend's, and he still holds it.

"If it happens, it happens," he said. "I feel like I've set myself up to have options when football ends."

Do not, however, mistake his shrug for a lack of ambition: Townsend has spent six years learning that football rarely cooperates with the game's greats, and he isn't about to start dictating his future now.

"If I go out and we have seven weeks left in our season and I play really well and have an opportunity to go pro, I definitely would want to do that," he said. "It's always been my dream since I was six years old. But I wouldn't say it's end-all or be-all with that, so I wouldn't say it's off the table. I still think that I have the ability to do it."

For now, however, he is staying put in the present.

"I'd say I'd have more of an idea by the time my season ends, just seeing how I perform and kind of having a better idea then," he said. "But right now, I'm just enjoying still playing the game."

As a player whose career featured no snaps as a first-year and no post-graduate offers until last April, Townsend knows the waiting game all too well, but what he has never done is wait quietly. Every stop on his route, from the scout team to the portal, has been defined by the same instinct to prove any doubters wrong.

"I know that I could play at this level," he said, "and anyone who's believed in me also knows that I could do so."

For Townsend, the sacks record may be settled, but his pursuit of excellence is not. In football, as Poppe will tell you, the play isn't over until the third effort.

caleb.lee
@columbiaspectator.com

Numbers game: A data-driven dive into Homecoming's history

BY EVAN VAN BRUNT, SOFÍA POLAR & EMILIA LEBEAU
Columbia Daily Spectator

Since the original 1948 showdown against Penn, Homecoming remains one of Columbia's most anticipated sporting events. Heading into the weekend and remaining conference play, the Lions post a confident 4-1 overall on the season, reminiscent of the 2024 conference-winning Columbia football team.

Now, the Light Blue will face off against Dartmouth, a frequent Homecoming rival for the last 15 seasons, at this year's showcase of school spirit. The Lions enter the matchup searching for a slump-breaker to a 10-year Homecoming skid against the Big Green.

Ahead of the pivotal game, Spectator dove into the quantitative stakes behind the biggest weekend on the football calendar.

A SEA OF LIGHT BLUE

Throughout the Lions' regular season, students, typically caught in the depths of Columbia's coursework, often refrain from traveling to 218th Street to see the Lions at Baker Athletics Complex. But on the special day, Baker transforms into a sea of blue, bringing together friends and families to enjoy a battle on the gridiron.

Homecoming attendance has ranged between 10,000 and 15,000 across the last few years. By modern Columbia standards, this is a schoolwide showout, compared to regular season games. However, attendance on Homecoming is only about 36 percent of what it was at the initial 1948 game—an all-time high of 35,000.

FORMER RIVALS

For the past 15 years, the Light Blue's Homecoming weekend rivalries have been split, alternating yearly between the Quakers and the Big Green. But in the big picture, the Lions' cast of Homecoming rivals expanded beyond what it is today.

While Penn still takes on a role as the Lions' principal Homecoming antagonist, Dartmouth is a historically infrequent opponent compared to the other members of the Ancient Eight. Instead, Princeton usurps the Big Green's position in all–time matchups, following the Quakers by three games. Harvard and Yale, historically feared names in the conference, round out the count with 26 matchups against the Light Blue between the two of them.

SOUR ENDINGS

Even across its wide range of opponents, Columbia consistently struggles to secure the Homecoming title.

Over 77 seasons of Homecoming football, the Lions have barely broken above 20 wins, losing roughly 71 percent of their big-day showdowns. To put this in perspective, the Light Blue has historically lost roughly 13 games for every five games it has won.

A STRUGGLE AGAINST THE FOREST

In the last 15 meetings between the teams, the Big Green has posed an especially difficult uphill battle for the Lions.

The Light Blue has not only lost 12 of its last 15 matchups against Dartmouth, but averaged roughly a 14-point difference in the same span. Furthermore, Columbia's point differential against the Big Green has been far and wide, ranging from a 2-point victory to a scoreless 56-point defeat.

THE RECORD-BREAKING UPSIDE

But in hints of glory, the Light Blue is able to piece the puzzle together, resulting in outstanding, time-honored drives downfield.

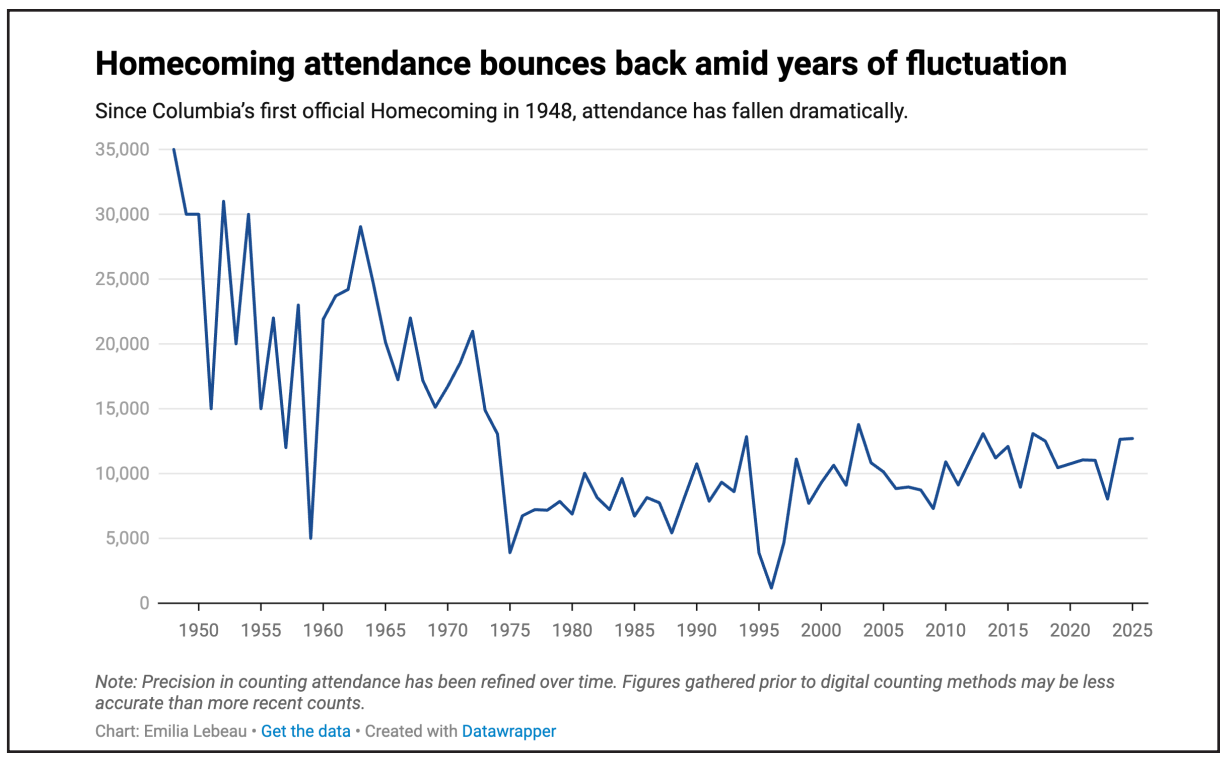
One of the record book's longest receptions is at the 2007 Homecoming game against Penn: Craig Hormann's pass to Austin Knowlin for a 90-yard breakaway.

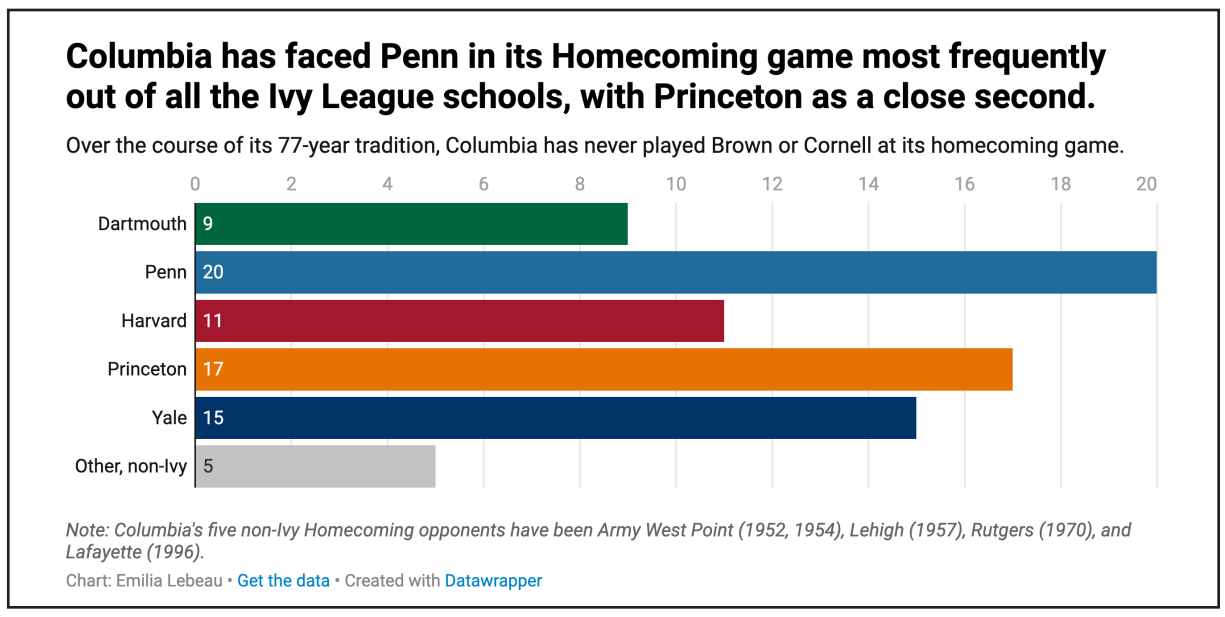
While the numbers tell the Light Blue's history, it is up to the team to defy convention. With Ivy League play ahead of them, the Lions aspire to rewrite their history against the Big Green.

evan.vanbrunt
@columbiaspectator.com

sofia.polar
@columbiaspectator.com

emilia.lebeau
@columbiaspectator.com





Can football break a 4-year Homecoming losing streak against Dartmouth?

BY ANDREW VINCENTI & HOLDEN LOMBARDO
Columbia Daily Spectator

Football will host Dartmouth on Oct. 24, looking to pick up its first Homecoming win since 2021.

The Lions (4-1, 1-1 Ivy) will be seeking revenge against the Big Green (2-3, 1-1 Ivy) in their week six matchup. Since head coach Jon Poppe joined the team in December 2023, the Light Blue has gone 0-2 against Dartmouth, including a 49-3 blowout loss last season.

Despite recent Homecoming blues, Poppe is confident about the Lions' chances.

"I think we've been pretty exciting this year, so chances are you're going to see an awesome contest and get to see some talented football players," Poppe said.

The Big Green heads to New York with serious concerns on both ends of the ball, averaging the fewest total yards per game while also allowing the most yards per game in the conference.

Offensively, Dartmouth has struggled to move the ball, especially through the air. Quarterback Grayson Saunier has completed just 53.4 percent of his passes this season—a drop from over 65 percent last season. Wide receiver Ky'Dric Fisher has emerged as Dartmouth's primary receiving threat, but the Big Green's passing attack has mustered only 176 yards per game.

Dartmouth's struggling air attack will face a challenge in the Lions' secondary, led by junior defensive back Carter McCray and sophomore defensive back MD Awe. The Light Blue's defensive backfield did not allow more than 127 yards from an opposing quarterback in the first three games of the season and posted four interceptions in last week's matchup against Penn.

The Big Green makes up for its unimposing passing attack with a respectable ground game. Dartmouth has averaged the fourth most rushing yards per game in the conference and is fifth for most touchdowns on the ground. Running back Myles Craddock stepped into the starting role, accumulating 375 rushing yards and three touchdowns. The Lions' run defense has struggled so far this season, but an improved showing against Penn saw it allow a season-low 72 rushing yards, giving the defensive front some much-needed momentum heading into Homecoming.

"We gotta be ultra disciplined on rush lanes," Poppe said. "We've got to be dialed into our gap assignments and understand they're going to add an extra hat in the run game with the running back as a lead blocker."

The Big Green's defense has faced its own struggles this season. The unit has been in the bottom half of the conference in points allowed, while allowing the most first downs. The defense has also struggled to apply pressure to opposing offenses, recording the fewest sacks and tying for the fewest interceptions in the conference.

Columbia's explosive offense will look to take advantage of the Big Green's defensive shortcomings. Senior quarterback Chase Goodwin has thrown an average of 297.8 yards per game through the first five games of the season, although turnovers have plagued the veteran quarterback. Another star performance from first-year wide receiver Bryce Coleman may be needed after he tallied 90 yards and three touchdowns on six receptions against Penn.

"Whether we're throwing to [Coleman] or not, he's playing a big role, and that sometimes doesn't always show with the stat sheet," Poppe said. "If he's taking double coverage, right, that's going to open up things for A) another receiver or B) our ground game."

Senior running back Griffin Johnson could also play a major role at Homecoming, facing a struggling Dartmouth run defense. He has dominated on the ground, already picking up 486 rushing yards and three touchdowns in his final season with the Light Blue.

"We're going to continue to do what we've done, which is, personnel-wise, take advantage of what we believe are our strengths versus their weaknesses, and then position people accordingly," Poppe said. "The O-line has done a good job, and Griff's done an unbelievable job of finding the seams."

ESMERALDA PAREDES / COLUMBIA DAILY SPECTATOR

SEEKING REVENGE | Columbia has the chance to avenge its 2024 Homecoming loss to Dartmouth.

andrew.vincenti
@columbiaspectator.com

holden.lombardo
@columbiaspectator.com

Spectator asks students about school spirit on campus

By Sarah Forde & Olivia Madkins
Columbia Daily Spectator

A Step Inside the Ring: Women's Wrestling's Road to Varsity

By Mia Martin
Audio & Podcasts Associate

The kids are alright: Football's first-years are taking college by storm

SAUMYA CHAUDHRY / ILLUSTRATIONS EDITOR

RISING ROOKIES | This year, football welcomed 28 new players to its roster.

BY AJAY BALAJE
Deputy Sports Editor

Some football players sit on the sideline for multiple seasons waiting for their opportunity. But this year, Columbia's rookies are making a massive impact right away.

The instant impact felt by this first-year class is atypical. Usually, newcomers spend their time on the bench, proving themselves through practice reps or special teams play. But this year, the Lions have trotted out numerous first-year starters on offense. While the early ascendancy may be surprising, they have spearheaded an offense ranked No. 10 in the Football Championship Subdivision in yards per game.

In their rebuild from last year's 2-8 season, the Lions did not bring in a single transfer over the offseason. Though the experience brought by returning athletes would likely improve the team, all recruits were first-year students. However, the expectation of bringing the program back to its 2024 championship glory spurred on the Light Blue's highest-ranked recruiting class since 2021.

Despite competing in the FCS and not offering athletic scholarships, student-athletes looking for an elite athletic performance program and unparalleled academic opportunities can find their home in Morningside Heights. For first-year wide receiver Gavin Barth, this combination ultimately led him to choose Columbia.

"I wanted to go to the best school with the best football, and I felt Columbia was the perfect match," Barth said. "Football is a four-or five-year thing unless you go to the NFL, so I sort of want to be prepared for after that, and I felt Columbia was gonna put me in the best situation for my life after football."

Beyond academic opportunities, the Columbia football community was a crucial selling point for the recruits. For Barth and first-year offensive lineman Rocco Costello, Columbia football felt like a natural fit.

"I chose here because the coaches felt like family to me. The players felt like family," Costello said.

"Honestly, the vibes were just immaculate," Barth said. "I got into Coach Poppe's office, and he offered me, and I committed on the spot because this place honestly just felt like home. That feeling has stayed throughout my time here, and I hope it stays like that for the next three or four years."

For football, the feeling was mutual. In the Lions' first game of the 2026 season, Barth saw significant game time, backing up fellow first-year wide receiver Bryce Coleman. He made impressive plays, catching three of his four targets for 34 yards and three consecutive first downs.

"It's sort of like a dream come true," Barth said. "Regardless of what level you're playing at, where you are, playing as a freshman is something everyone dreams of."

Costello quickly joined Barth on the gridiron. After an injury to senior right guard Sean Kimani, Costello stepped up and assumed the starting job. Despite playing out of position, Costello impressed in his stint at guard, keeping the Lions' front five in good shape.

"I came in at center, and I ended up working my tail off in camp to prove that I can also play guard," Costello said.

By the time the Princeton game rolled around, Barth, Costello, and Coleman had secured starting spots, giving the Lions three first-year starters on offense. For Barth, being able to take the field with members of his class was a special experience.

"Bryce is my guy. Rocco's my guy," Barth said. "I feel like they put in the work, I put in the work, we as a team put in the work. So for that to show on the field was just awesome."

Costello shared the sentiment, noting the bonds he had made with his fellow first-years off the field.

"We're all great friends. We're all tight. We all hang out after practice, after class, whatever it is," Costello said. "You know, we eat together. We're going to JJ's late at night."

Since the beginning of the season, this year's first-year class has thoroughly impressed, giving the Light Blue an edge all over the field. But while this recruiting class is the highest-profile group the Lions have seen in years, neither Barth nor Costello seemed too worried about their rankings.

"The outside people can say what they want. We know what we got here," Barth said. "We're just going to continue to grind, don't let anything out there affect us. We do what we do."

ajay.balaje
@columbiaspectator.com

Bryce Coleman is flying. Catch him if you can.

LYNN FU / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

COLEMAN EFFECT | First-year wide receiver Bryce Coleman has quickly carved out a starring role in Columbia's offense while settling into life in Morningside Heights.

BY DIANE LANG
Senior Staff Writer

Bryce Coleman's happy place is the football field.

In his few weeks as a Lion, the first-year wide receiver has already made a mark, living up to the three-star ranking he earned as a recruit. The first time he took the field for the Light Blue against Lafayette College on Sept. 19, Coleman hit the ground running. He reeled in a touchdown grab on Columbia's opening scoring drive and did not slow down. Coleman recorded seven receptions for 127 yards and two touchdowns en route to the thrilling overtime victory.

This dazzling performance earned him the Ivy League Co-Rookie of the Week honors, and Coleman's play since then has proven it was not a fluke, earning his second Rookie of the Week on Oct. 12 for his nine catches against Marist University. The newcomer, a consistent bright spot on Columbia's offense, has scored in every game this season. Just four games into his college career, he looks comfortable in the starting lineup and in the end zone, leading the Lions and ranking third in the league in receiving yards.

Reflecting on Coleman's early performance, head coach Jon Poppe had a message for future opponents.

"I think as a defensive coach, you're going to pay attention to him a little bit more now," he said.

It's easy to see why.

Few players have made the immediate impact that Coleman has. Yet he is unfazed by the pressure of being a standout rookie at the Division I level, seeing it less as a surprise and more as an inevitable responsibility. A lover of the process, he believes that his work prepared him for the moment.

"I put in a lot of work, a lot of extra hours, underground work that not everyone sees. So when I come out here, I kind of expect results from myself, just because of everything that I've done, my parents have done, all the sacrifices," he said. "I feel like I owe it to them to produce, really. And just the coaches believing in me, it's my duty to make them right in putting me out there."

Now that the work is paying off in big ways during games, Coleman is experiencing the fruits of his labor.

"This is all that I really dreamed of: playing Division I football and just coming in, making an impact."

Hailing from Irvine, California, Coleman is no stranger to putting in long, hot days to stand out from the pack.

"Even in the hot sun in the summer, like 94 degrees, you still got to get it in," he said. "Putting in those extra hours consistently, day in and day out, because everyone's putting them in, but you have to separate yourself somehow," he said.

For many student-athletes, balancing a full academic workload and daily college life along with a packed athletic schedule can lead to burnout. For Coleman, it's all part of the game he loves.

"If you really like football, like the behind-the-scenes stuff, even when not everyone's watching, you're gonna like the process."

Long before Coleman put on Columbia's Pantone 290 uniform, he and his family had their eyes set on a member of the Ancient Eight. While the stricter Ivy League rules often make recruits ranked as highly as Coleman go somewhere they can profit more heavily off of name, image, and likeness, and play as graduate students, his parents emphasized education.

"My parents always put school first," he said. "Ivy League has been something that my parents have wanted me to go to since I was 10, really. So just getting those opportunities is really a full circle moment because when you have those dreams and then they finally come to pass, and you have those options, it's really a blessing."

When it came time to narrow down the programs courting Coleman, Columbia stood out.

"It was a system that I felt like they were gonna use my talents and make me the best player possible," he said. "Maximizing my potential was really all that I was looking for in a program and people that were gonna develop me and make me better every day."

In addition to the football program, Coleman said he chose Columbia for the opportunities it can provide long after his playing days are over.

"There's a lot of years that you won't be playing football," he said. "So just forming those relationships, meeting these people on this campus, in this school, is gonna help you for the rest of your life."

Coleman has long used football as a way to build relationships. While he's still getting used to the New York City weather and adjusting to life several thousands of miles away from home for the first time, the wide receiver is making it his mission to bond with his teammates and forge a community.

"The community is really good. I've met a lot of great people. I have a lot of good teachers, and so, obviously, I mean it's Columbia, so it's going to be a change, and you're going to have to get used to it. But so far it's going good," he said.

His community includes Coleman's recruiting class, one of the strongest Columbia has had in recent years. This year's class arrived with eight all-state honorees, four state champions, and three three-star prospects, including Coleman. This comes as the Lions look to bounce back from a disappointing 2025 season where they finished last in the Ivy League, winning just one conference game.

"We have a lot of great young guys who have come in and already made an impact," he said. "Our class is really good, it's really competitive. A lot of guys who just love playing football and a really talented, athletic class, and a lot of big, big dudes. And on the offensive side, we have a lot of explosive guys."

Coleman sees the new Lions as having the ability to elevate the team back to the heights of their 2024 Ivy League championship and carry on the season into the Football Championship Subdivision playoffs, which the Ivy League now earns an automatic bid into.

"They all love football. They all put in the work. So having that, having them, I can tell this program we're on the uprise. We're gonna keep getting better every year."

Coleman said he looks forward to continuing to show up for the Light Blue, playing with the enthusiasm he has brought since earning a starting spot on the roster. As the Lions continue their season, Coleman is just getting started on what will be a long and exciting four years in Morningside Heights.

"I'm a really high energy guy," he said. "I'm gonna show how I feel all the time. I play with a lot of passion, it's just who I am. When I get on the football field, it's just the happiest place."

diane.lang
@columbiaspectator.com

Congress says it is saving college sports. **Student athletes disagree.**

BY NICHOLAS FINK
Sports Editor

GEORGIA PAULOS / COLUMBIA DAILY SPECTATOR

HOUSE VOTE | The bill faces an uncertain future in the House of Representatives.

The Senate passed the Protect College Sports Act, a monumental bill aiming to federally regulate collegiate athletics, on Sept. 28.

The proposed legislation would transform college sports, granting antitrust protections for the NCAA; codifying the student-athlete revenue sharing cap and permissible name, image, and likeness licensing deals; restricting transfers; and codifying five-year eligibility windows.

Proponents of the Protect College Sports Act include some of the most powerful individuals and bodies in collegiate athletics, such as the NCAA and the Southeastern Conference. They argue that the act creates one stable national regulatory framework, reduces roster turnover through transfer limits, and allows more effective enforcement of NCAA rules.

Many student-athletes and labor advocacy groups, however, have come out adamantly against the bill, including some at Columbia.

Opponents characterize the bill as a reaction against the rise of athlete empowerment brought on by name, image, and likeness licensing deals, arguing that it weakens the ability of athletes to collectively organize and bargain, and undermines universities' obligations to uphold Title IX protections. The NAACP, AFL-CIO, and numerous collegiate and professional players associations have all voiced opposition as well.

"Here the NCAA and Governor Baker, as president of the NCAA, has sown this narrative of chaos for about three years, and that lawsuits and state laws and others make college sports ungovernable," Robert Boland, CC '87, said.

Boland is a sports law professor at Seton Hall University who oversaw the athletic department at Pennsylvania State University as its athletic integrity officer. He has represented student-athletes in their eligibility lawsuits against the NCAA and was a varsity football player and wrestler at Columbia. Boland worries that the bill will be harmful to student-athletes and small- and medium-sized institutions like Columbia, particularly with its negative downstream effects on recruitment and competition.

"If Congress looks in every three or four years, will the NCAA be able to pass rules that are more onerous against athletes, their earnings, their ability to challenge the NCAA, and so it's pretty negative, pretty negative bill in terms of athletes' rights," he said.

Boland specifically pointed to the antitrust exemption this bill granted to the NCAA as potentially impacting student-athlete rights.

"As a lawyer who's been in this space and somebody who cares about this, it has been the ability to use antitrust against the NCAA to gain advantage for athletes that have gotten athletes to where they are right now. The fact that they are earning a big piece of NIL dollars, that they have been able to get a larger share of the enterprise," Boland said.

Under the bill, the NCAA would be shielded from federal and state antitrust laws when enforcing the bill's rules on athlete pay, eligibility, and transfers. The bill would also override state laws on those subjects, including New York State's. Previously, Boland argued, the state's antitrust and NIL laws were seen as more lenient and frequently used in lawsuits by student-athletes against the NCAA. Lawsuits already filed could generally continue.

"It's pretty remarkable that Congress, which has at least since World War II never limited the rights of any group to pursue antitrust remedies, is choosing to do that against college athletes," Boland said.

Avalyn Mostyn, CC '28, spent her first two years at Columbia as a sprinter on the track and field team. She said athletes regularly received emails about NCAA rule changes that were proposed, passed, and reversed, making it difficult to know which rules applied to them.

"There's not as much talk in athletic circles as there could be, or as you might expect, just because people are so used to the fluctuating regulation and not actually knowing where a lot of the rules lie, and not having much faith that much of the regulation is actually going to be done in favor of the athlete," Mostyn said.

Mostyn found the changing rules challenging after an injury in her first-year season.

"I didn't run indoor season my freshman year because I got foot surgery, and trying to figure out whether or not I would be eligible for a medical waiver, ... that whole process was really difficult, especially as regulations are changing," she said.

Mostyn said the bill's answer to that instability, in limiting athletes' ability to challenge the NCAA in court, is the wrong one.

"I understand there is a lot of legislation that the NCAA has to deal with, and that can be really difficult. I just think it's the worst possible way to address that," she said. "I just think that the equity considerations of student athletes should be given higher priority when developing regulatory and legislative rules like this, and I don't think they are."

Cami Neal, CC '25, a former softball player, was a leader in the Student-Athlete Advisory Committee at Columbia, an advocacy group for student-athletes. She said she has watched outside decisions reshape athletes' lives since high school, when the NCAA changed its rules so that athletes could not be recruited until Sept. 1 of their junior year. She was concerned that this bill was an instance of people who are not college athletes making decisions without considering their perspectives.

"It's just so affected by people outside of the actual sports environment themselves," she said. "It feels like people are making decisions about what it's like to be a college athlete and what is best for college athletes without actually taking the opinions and considerations of people actually operating within that space and being affected by these bills and rules."

The bill would require current or recently graduated athletes to make up at least a third of the NCAA's governing boards and rule-making committees. But Neal, in her own time on SAAC, saw the limitations of student-athlete voices, even in formal roles. She said that the committee's reach was limited to campus-wide initiatives, but even those depended on what the administration was willing to change.

"You don't necessarily have too much of a pull even sitting in that president position. I think less so than people think," she said.

Boland also noted that the bill may strain the abilities of the athletic departments at small schools to keep up with the wealthiest conferences.

On top of the House settlement's revenue-sharing cap of around $21 million, the Protect College Sports Act adds two more ways to compensate athletes directly. The first is a retention fund exemption, which allows institutions to exceed the revenue share cap by up to $22.5 million per academic year exclusively on athletes who have already completed a full season with the school. The second is a nonrevenue generating sport exemption, allowing as much as an additional $5 million in compensation.

This raises the high-end costs of recruiting and retaining student athletes to nearly $50 million, a number greater than the total reported expenses of Columbia Athletics in 2025.

"The increase in funding from $21.3 million to $48 million, even though much of the increase is based on retention, will drive up the cost of competition beyond what most schools can handle," Boland said.

Columbia, like the rest of the Ivy League, opted out of revenue sharing under the House settlement, which would not change with this legislation. However, many of its opponents did not, leading to potential downstream competitive effects. In the race to stay atop revenue-generating sports like football, Boland believes that schools may scale back Olympic and nonrevenue generating sports.

"I think the other part of it that we're going to see, is we're going to see schools that are smaller than Columbia probably either scale back their athletic programs or reconsider their level of competition," he said. "I don't think Columbia has to reconsider its level of competition, but a lot of the schools Columbia plays outside the Ivy League may be forced to do that."

The bill does include some protections for these sports, but they are only temporary. Schools with at least $80 million in annual athletics revenue would have to keep as many total roster spots and scholarships in nonrevenue sports, including women's and Olympic sports, as they offered in 2024-25, but only for nine years. Those between $50 million to $80 million would face the same requirement but for four years.

For athletes in these sports, program cuts are already part of the collegiate landscape. Macy Pine, CC '25, is a former Columbia diver. She expressed concern that many large institutions may eliminate programs to meet the higher compensation ceiling.

"Everybody sees the big market sport sides of the NIL and the transfer portal," she said. "But very few people are seeing the small market sports side of that, which is that programs like diving are getting cut left and right."

In 2025, coming off of its fourth-straight NCAA championship, the University of Virginia eliminated its diving program, citing the new financial landscape brought on by the House settlement. Pine noted potential difficulties with transferring for athletes in cut programs.

"If the NCAA champions are doing that, other teams are going to follow suit," Pine said. "I want divers to be able to compete the very next season if their team gets cut."

As a low-income student, Pine said she might not have been able to attend Columbia had she not been recruited as a diver, and she worries that fewer roster spots in college sports would close that path for others.

"I worry that it would kind of further narrow the socioeconomic diversity of Columbia," she said.

Pine said Columbia is fortunate to have a women's basketball team that draws real support, but that is not the case at most schools, putting those programs at risk.

"Women's sports are often seen as an afterthought or a secondary counterpart to their men's teams," she said. "If we let revenue dictate how much we prioritize supporting emotionally and financially these sports, women are gonna get forgotten about."

The bill now faces a vote in the House of Representatives, which returns to session after the midterm elections, and upcoming midterm election outcomes may impact its future. The vote is far from a sure thing, however, with Boland believing that the House will draft its own version of the bill.

"I'm kind of hoping the House messes it up," he said.

For Pine, the stakes come down to what college sports are supposed to be.

"This is college. This is an educational institution, and they have an obligation to their students, regardless of gender, to look after their athletes, to fund their sports, and to give them their due attention and praise when they do things well, regardless of whether or not it's a quote unquote marketable sport," she said.

nicholas.fink
@columbiaspectator.com

Football scrapes by in its first conference win against Penn

BY HOLDEN LOMBARDO & EVAN VAN BRUNT
Columbia Daily Spectator

Football rallied from a 17-point deficit to survive an Oct. 16 conference nail-biter against Penn, snatching its first Ivy League victory this season. With the win, the Light Blue picked up a first conference win ahead of Homecoming.

After an action-packed first half, the game ended in victory for the Lions (4-1, 1-1 Ivy) following a chaotic conclusion of clock mismanagement by Penn (2-3, 0-2 Ivy) that made national headlines.

The game kicked off with a rough stretch for the Light Blue. After a three-and-out in their first drive, the Lions allowed a Quaker rushing touchdown before senior quarterback Chase Goodwin threw an interception on an underthrown lob to first-year wide receiver Gavin Barth.

On the defense, Columbia showed an early glimpse of its capability, holding the Quakers to a field goal and giving their offense a chance to cut into Penn's lead.

On the next drive, following a deep ball to sophomore wide receiver Beckett Robinson for 45 yards, Goodwin sailed a pass to star first-year wide receiver Bryce Coleman in tight coverage in the end zone. Coleman hauled the diving catch over his left shoulder to give the Lions their first points of the day.

However, the game slipped away from the Lions as the Quakers scored on back-to-back possessions. A 66-yard kick return and an unnecessary roughness penalty on Columbia set up one Quaker touchdown, while a failed fourth-down conversion that bounced off the hands of junior wide receiver Hutch Crow paved the way for Penn quarterback Karson Siqueiros-Lasky's second touchdown pass in less than four minutes.

Down 17 points early in the second quarter, the Quakers came knocking again in Columbia territory when senior linebacker AJ George picked off a shotgun pass by Siqueiros-Lasky to swing the game's momentum back toward the Light Blue.

The Lions dominated the rest of the half on both sides of the ball. Senior running back Griffin Johnson led the charge on the next possession, taking off for several explosive rushes before punching the ball in for a 3-yard touchdown. The Quakers had little time to respond before junior defensive lineman Caleb Solomon made a diving toe-tap interception at midfield.

Columbia capitalized on the turnover with a quick trip to the end zone, as Goodwin connected with Coleman for an 11-yard touchdown over the head of a Penn defender.

However, Penn's offense kicked into gear on the next drive, moving the ball to Columbia's 13-yard line. With 30 seconds left in the half, the Lion defense forced a third down before bringing the blitz against Siqueiros-Lasky, who threw the ball up under pressure. Junior defensive back Carter McCray jumped the pass to secure Columbia's third interception of the quarter.

In the third quarter, Penn made its way downfield into Columbia territory. However, when Siquerios-Lasky scrambled towards the end zone, McCray forced a fumble on the stray quarterback. Siquerios-Lasky was able to recover the runaway ball at the 1-yard line. Despite the close yardage, the Lions held Penn to a field goal with help from sophomore defensive back MD Awe, as he narrowly pushed a mid-air receiver out of the end zone.

Opening the fourth quarter, Goodwin hit Coleman in stride on a 38-yard pass to set up first-and-goal at the Quakers' 3-yard line. However, after a false start penalty backed the Lions up, Goodwin's pass was deflected at the line and picked off.

Following a Quaker punt, the Lions saw their opportunity to pull ahead in a drive that spanned 69 yards and more than four minutes. From Penn's 9-yard line, Goodwin again found Coleman for his third touchdown pass of the day as the Light Blue took its first lead of the day.

After trading punts, the Quakers hoped to erase Columbia's 1-point lead when Siquerios-Lasky threw his fourth interception of the game. The Lions' offense failed to capitalize on the turnover, though, and a punt gave Penn the ball back with 52 seconds left.

GIADA ROBINSON / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

WILD ENDING | First-year wide receiver Bryce Coleman hauled in three receiving touchdowns—the highest tally in his time with the Lions.

The Quakers began the drive from their 19-yard line, but a few quick passes moved the ball to Columbia's 36-yard line with an opportunity for a game-winning field goal and 11 seconds on the clock.

However, the Quakers chose not to spike the ball and stop the clock, instead rushing their field goal unit onto the field in a hectic operation on first down. With several offensive players hurrying to the sideline, the kicker did not get set until two seconds remained in the game, and the confusion resulted in an attempt that fell short as time expired.

holden.lombardo
@columbiaspectator.com

evan.vanbrunt
@columbiaspectator.com

IVY LEAGUE STANDINGS

	HARVARD	PRINCETON	COLUMBIA	CORNELL	YALE	DARTMOUTH	BROWN	PENN
IVY	2-0	2-0	1-1	1-1	1-1	1-1	0-2	0-2
IVY PCT	1.000	1.000	.500	.500	.500	.500	.000	.000
OVERALL	5-0	4-1	4-1	3-2	3-2	2-3	2-3	2-3
PCT.	1.000	.800	.800	.600	.600	.400	.400	.400
STREAK	W5	W4	W2	W1	L1	W1	L1	L1

Oren Milstein, CC ’20, Business ’28, reflects on 2016 Homecoming breakthrough

Despite inclement weather, Milstein led the Lions to a 9-7 win over Dartmouth, breaking a 15-year Homecoming losing streak.

BY AVELINA MOLEY STOLTZ
Columbia Daily Spectator

Ten years ago, cold rain and 40 mile-per-hour winds set the scene for football’s 2016 Homecoming showdown against Dartmouth.

After losing 15 of their last Homecoming matchups, the Lions’ hope matched the big day’s melancholy overcast. But as the game concluded, the sun shined down on the Light Blue after toppling the Big Green in a reversal of fortune. Columbia’s 9-7 victory came with substantial help from former first-year kicker Oren Milstein, CC ’20, Business ’28, scoring the team’s only points of the game with three field goals.

The Lions’ start to the 2016 season was rocky to say the least, entering Homecoming with four losses and just one close win over Wagner College. But after Milstein’s outstanding performance, the Light Blue victory over Dartmouth not only marked the program’s first Homecoming win since 2000, but also its first conference win of the year. In addition, the novice field goal specialist was named the John Toner Homecoming player of the game, converting 31, 20, and 33-yard field goals.

Looking back, however, the kicker viewed the victory as a meaningful change for the culture of football in Morningside Heights. The Lions built on the momentum from his first year, leading to a successful sophomore season that ended 5-2 in conference play and 8-2 overall.

“We like to think our time there was a turnaround or a winning point in the program,” Milstein said.

For Milstein, now a student at the Business School, the game remains a memorable experience from his time as a Lion. However, as a first-year, it was still an uphill battle—both on and off the gridiron.

“I just remember it being overwhelming and then the season not starting off so great,” Milstein said regarding his transition to New York City as a first-year.

But the learning curve didn’t come with a grace period. In the second game of the season, Milstein was thrown in as the Lions’ starting kicker, drilling 3 extra points in his first two games. Just weeks before his Homecoming debut, Milstein not only helped to secure Columbia’s first win of the season against Wagner, but he sealed his name in the Lions’ record book by kicking five field goals—the best field goal accuracy in program history—in the pouring rain to lead the Light Blue to a 15-13 win.

The Homecoming game arrived as the Lions searched for their second win of the season and first victory within the Ancient Eight.

“It was really cold and rainy, and it was a miserable environment,” he said. “It is fun football weather, but being wet and cold is not ideal.”

Still, the inclement weather seemed to work in the Lions’ favor.

“We thrived in some of the messier environments, so it kind of worked for us to disrupt the flow of everything,” Milstein said.

Up against a dominant Dartmouth team which had not lost to the Lions since 2008, Milstein understood that the whole team would need to work together as a unit to defeat its Goliath.

“The defense was really, really good and kept us in a lot of games, and the offense made their timely plays that got us to that situation,” Milstein said. “I played a role in it, but as a team, when it was special, it was because we all came together really, really well.”

Milstein’s stellar performance was the final piece to the Light Blue’s puzzle, ending a 15-year Homecoming losing streak and breaking the cycle of Columbia’s history with losing sprees.

After two very successful seasons at Columbia for Milstein, making 20 of 26 field-goal attempts and 42 of 44 extra-point attempts he missed the next one due to injury and his last season for an undisclosed reason. After graduating, the former kicker worked in healthcare consulting, but sports eventually pulled him back in a very different role. After a college career derailed by injury and the pandemic, Milstein made a comeback, pursuing the Olympic sport skeleton full-time, competing for Team Israel and serving as an alternate at this year’s Olympics. Now, back on campus, he hopes to keep up more with Columbia football.

Milstein noted his confidence in the current coaching staff, especially head coach Jon Poppe, who was the defensive backs coach during Milstein’s time with the program.

“I do think the program’s in really good hands with Coach Poppe,” the kicker said. “He’s always a very intelligent coach, and it’s pretty cool that they brought him back.”

A decade after that rainy afternoon and its electric atmosphere, the Homecoming win is a reminder for a 4-1 Lions team to find their footing amid difficult circumstances and losing streaks. For Milstein, the memory goes beyond his own extraordinary role in the win. It is about learning to navigate new experiences and challenging games as a team, and in doing so, shifting the Light Blue’s trajectory for the better.

avelina.moleystoltz
@columbiaspectator.com

COLUMBIA ATHLETICS / COURTESY OF

KICKIN’ IT | Now at the Business School, Milstein’s return to Morningside Heights rekindles memories of his time with the Lions.

‘For the students, by the students’: How the Columbia Pep Band built a culture of service and leadership

BY ROBBY SWAN & MELINA NATH
Columbia Daily Spectator

Despite only being founded in 2022, the Columbia Pep Band has built a significant presence on campus.

The band is designed to accommodate all skill levels, including students who grew up playing an instrument and those starting an instrument for the first time.

Student leadership is at the core of the pep band, Brent Morden, CC ’19, emphasized. Morden has directed the pep band since its inception in fall 2022 after graduating magna cum laude with a B.A. in music. Outside of directing the band, he is a real estate agent, a freelance musician, a vocal coach, and works as an adjunct professor and choir director at Hofstra University.

Morden views his busy schedule and return to Columbia not simply as a job but as a commitment to giving back to his alma mater. Managing a schedule that spans church performances on Long Island, real estate walk-ins in Queens, where he lives, and private vocal coaching, he approaches all his work with an emphasis on service.

“I see everything I do as a form of service. The question I ask myself is, ‘How can I serve, musically or otherwise, managerially, and so on?” Morden said. “Really, the pep band for me is a form of service, and I’m grateful to be able to give back, as I said, to Columbia in this way.”

While directing the pep band, Morden has meticulously worked to build the infrastructure for a student board that is able to accommodate all the group’s needs.

Columbia Pep Band president Maxwell Ma, CC ’28, is the band’s principal student leader. An alto saxophonist who began his pep band journey during his first semester, Ma’s responsibilities as president revolve around band-wide coordination and working with the club’s other leadership positions to fill in gaps.

“As president, you essentially fill in the gaps, and to some extent, you also are every role,” Ma said.

When the pep band was started under Columbia Athletics in 2022, it lacked a cohesive student governing body. Over the past four years, Morden worked alongside various student musicians to build the board, which is designed to give students complete ownership over the band’s daily operations and growth.

“This band is for the students, by the students, in a manner of speaking. The student members of the pep band are the heart and soul of our band, and we would not be able to function without the vision and effort of our student leaders,” Morden said.

At 33 musicians, the pep band currently boasts the largest roster since its founding. Ma stated that a priority of his during his time leading the band is to continue increasing the number of participants, specifically in the brass section. Morden also shared a similar desire to continue increasing personnel, emphasizing that students play an essential role in the process.

“These are undergraduate students primarily who really want to take ownership of growing this band, who share in my vision and Columbia Athletics’ vision to grow and shape this band into a well-oiled machine,” Morden said.

Morden shared that the current student leadership roles are the result of the band’s infrastructure being built over the past four years. He characterizes the band as a collaborative environment.

“The best teachers learn from their students, and I learn from our student leaders as well,” Morden said. “They teach me how to be a better manager and a better director, and if I do my job well, I am able to create that environment where our student leaders can flourish, and the band flourishes all together.”

The pep band gathers in the Riverside Church on Sundays to rehearse for upcoming games. Alongside Columbia classics such as “Roar, Lion, Roar” and “Who Owns New York,” the band practices a collection of popular songs—from Demi Lovato’s “Confident” to Bruno Mars’ “Runaway Baby”—and formations for field performances.

“For Homecoming, we’re planning to do just pure Chappell Roan,” Ma said. “We’re going to do ‘Hot to Go,’ ‘Red Wine Supernova,’ and ‘Good Luck, Babe!’ What I want the audience to do is like, ‘Wow, I know that song.’”

The band’s schedule reaches a crescendo around major campus events, such as Homecoming. A typical weekend for the band involves early-morning equipment preparation, logistics, loading buses at Riverside Church for travel to Baker Stadium, and maintaining high energy among the crowd regardless of the game’s outcome.

Beyond simply growing roster numbers and refining shows, Morden and Ma have set their sights on expanding the entire scope of the pep band’s on- and off-campus presence.

“We were invited these last few years to fly out and play the NCAA tournament and the Ivy League championship tournament, which we weren’t able to do since we didn’t quite have the numbers yet, but I see that coming on the horizon,” Morden said. “I think that’s definitely within our grasp the next few years.”

While the national stage is in sight, the pep band will be back to its local roots, performing for the Columbia community once again for Homecoming.

robby.swan
@columbiaspectator.com

melina.nath
@columbiaspectator.com

LYNN FU / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

HIGH ENERGY | The Columbia Pep Band is a staple of Homecoming, bringing high energy through its songs.

Spec Sports Predicts the Game

	NICHOLAS FINK *Sports Editor*	AJAY BALAJE *Deputy Sports Editor*	EVAN VAN BRUNT *Deputy Sports Editor*	ANDREW VINCENTI *Deputy Sports Editor*	HOLDEN LOMBARDO *Staff Writer*
Winner	Columbia	Columbia	Columbia	Columbia	Columbia
Score	24-16	35-31	34-28	27-23	30-27
Player to Watch	Griffin Johnson	AJ George	Bryce Coleman	MD Awe	Beckett Robinson
Spec says:	Coleman has rightly drawn plaudits this season, but Griffin Johnson’s superb play should not go unnoticed. If Columbia wants to break down a stout Dartmouth defense, setting the tone with Johnson may be the best way.	Columbia’s defense makes plays. It won’t shut Dartmouth down, but there’s going to be a big fourth-quarter sack or pick to put this game away, and I wouldn’t be surprised to see George make it happen.	To overcome a struggling Big Green defense, the Lions must maximize red zone visits. Prioritizing quick yardage, Columbia should leverage Bryce Coleman’s red zone success against press coverage.	Columbia is going to be fueled by the Homecoming crowd. An explosive passing attack and strong secondary may be too much for the Big Green to overcome.	To win their first homecoming game in five years, the Lions are going to need Goodwin to throw the ball deep. Watch for Robinson to be on the other end of a few crucial shots down the field.

Columbia postdoctoral workers union calls off strike, reaches tentative agreement with University

BY JUSTINE PASCUTTI & SPENCER DAVIS
Columbia Daily Spectator

Columbia's postdoctoral workers union reached a tentative agreement with the University during an Oct. 20 bargaining session, calling off its plan to strike on Oct. 22.

The union, Columbia Postdoctoral Workers–United Auto Workers, received a "last, best, and final offer" from the University on Oct. 16, but negotiated three major changes to the contract at the Oct. 20 bargaining session, Anna Yoney, CPW-UAW unit chair and bargaining committee member, told Spectator.

"We moved Columbia on some of the main sticking points for us in their last offer, and with that movement we were able to reach a unanimous tentative agreement," Yoney said.

A University spokesperson did not comment on the agreement in time for publication.

The union, which represents about 1,600 postdoctoral and associate researchers at the University, has been bargaining for a successor contract since its 2023 agreement expired in July, demanding higher base salaries, greater wage adjustments for current employees, and improved housing assistance.

At the Oct. 20 bargaining session, the union negotiated a $500 increase of the minimum salary for postdoctoral workers, shortened the duration of the contract by one year, and secured a $300 bonus for workers months sooner than the University had previously offered, Yoney said. She added, however, that there had been no movement on the union's housing article since Oct. 16.

"Columbia can and should have done more," Yoney said. "But I think our bargaining committee, we reached this agreement. This was the best possible agreement we could reach in this moment."

The union announced the tentative agreement in an Instagram post the night of Oct. 20, after calling for a picket that would have initiated the strike the next morning.

The tentative agreement was unanimously approved by the seven-member bargaining committee and will be sent to union members for ratification Oct. 23, Yoney said. Voting will remain open for one week, she added.

justine.pascutti
@columbiaspectator.com

spencer.davis
@columbiaspectator.com

JACKSON DILKS / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

SIKE ON STRIKE | The union, Columbia Postdoctoral Workers–United Auto Workers, represents about 1,600 postdoctoral and associate researchers at the University.

Why Columbia's tax filings show millions in payments to unaffiliated nonprofits

BY SIMON LETON
Staff Writer

In September, The Intercept reported that Columbia funneled hundreds of thousands of dollars to pro-Israel nonprofits over the last decade, based on a review of the University's tax filings.

The article points to payments the University made to the Israel on Campus Coalition and an affiliate of the American Israel Public Affairs Committee, the biggest pro-Israel lobbying group in the United States, totaling $175,000 in fiscal year 2024—the same period as Hamas' Oct. 7, 2023, attack on Israel, the beginning of Israel's war in Gaza, and the April 2024 "Gaza Solidarity Encampment."

According to a University spokesperson, the payments were made through donor-advised funds, a fundraising mechanism through which donors can recommend payments to other nonprofits out of donor-funded accounts operated by the University.

In interviews with Spectator, nonprofit finance experts said that the initiative allows Columbia to act as an intermediary for donations, and that the University does not make decisions about where the funds are ultimately sent. Still, pro-Palestinian affiliates criticized the funds, citing the fact that they show up on the University's tax filings, potentially leading to a perception of bias.

"The donor-advised fund invites the donor to make suggestions, which are almost always followed," David Schizer, dean emeritus of the Law School, explained. Schizer teaches a lecture at the Law School on federal income taxation and wrote a book on nonprofit management.

Of the nearly $14 million in donations made through Columbia's donor-advised funds in 2024, the donations to the AIPAC affiliate and the Israel on Campus Coalition accounted for just 1.2 percent of the total.

Harvard University, Yale University, and Stanford University, as well as many other U.S. universities, also maintain similar initiatives as part of their fundraising suites, showing similar sets of pro-Israel donations. In fiscal year 2024, for instance, donor-advised funds at Yale and Dartmouth College paid $1.36 million and $36,000 to the Friends of the Israel Defense Forces, respectively.

To establish a donor-advised fund at Columbia, donors must donate a minimum of $1 million and eventually donate at least half of their contributions to the University. The University holds the donations in its account and invests the money, with donors divvying up as little as 5 percent of the account's balance each year.

Funds not given to Columbia can be paid to any public charity qualified by the Internal Revenue Service, according to the University's website, and cannot be made for personal benefit or to satisfy any legally binding pledges.

"Sponsors are usually quite flexible to the recommendations of the donors," Danielle Vance-McMullen, co-founder and research director at the DAF Research Collaborative and assistant professor at DePaul University, said in an interview with Spectator. "The trend overall is toward maximum flexibility, as long as the recipient charity is a registered 501(c)(3) charity in good standing."

Vance-McMullen said it would be "unusual" for a donor-advised fund to "restrict giving ideologically, unless that was part of their core purpose." A Catholic donor-advised fund, she said, might block donations to Planned Parenthood.

For Joseph Howley, associate professor of classics, who is quoted in the Intercept article, the funds are "bad for the University's reputation" because "the University can essentially be obliged to associate itself with those groups at the whim or direction of a donor," he said in an interview with Spectator.

Maryam Alwan, GS '25, a prominent pro-Palestinian alum, who is also quoted in The Intercept's coverage, wrote in a statement to Spectator that further explanation of how donor-advised funds work did not alleviate her perception of the University's responsibility.

"While it is enlightening to know that these donations are not directly from the University's money, that fact does not change that Columbia is fully politically aligned with donation recipients like AIPAC and the Israel on Campus Coalition," she wrote.

A University spokesperson did not respond to a request for comment on Howley's and Alwan's criticism.

Over the last five years, Columbia donor-advised funds have distributed around $13 million dollars on average each year to the University and external organizations, according to the University's tax filings. Investment in donor-advised funds, however, has fallen since the 2010s, those filings show.

Schizer and Vance-McMullen said that there are several reasons why interested donors may give to donor-advised funds rather than directly to Columbia or to other charities, including for tax benefits and so they can take advantage of the University's investing expertise.

JACKSON DILKS / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

WHO DECIDES? | Columbia has distributed around $13 million on average from its donor-advised funds annually over the last five years, records show.

The IRS allows donors to count donations to donor-advised funds as equivalent to direct donations to charity, meaning that these contributions qualify donors for tax deductions, even though the donated funds can sit in the University's accounts for years before ever reaching a charitable cause.

"What a donor-advised fund does instead is it allows you to commit the money to charity, take your tax deduction, and then give grants over the years," Schizer said.

Schizer added that donor-advised fund sponsors use the program to incentivize donations by giving more flexibility to donors.

"They're providing a service to the people who made the donations," Schizer said. "They're implementing the advice of their donors."

Schizer noted that changes to the federal tax code in 2017 and 2025 made donor-advised funds more attractive by incentivizing donors to combine several years of charitable contributions into a single tax year, allowing them to maximize their tax deductions while still splitting up their donations across multiple years.

Columbia donor-advised funds allow donor contributions to grow alongside the University's endowment, which has had an almost 8 percent annual net investment return over the past 10 years. Donor-advised funds also allow donors to commit to philanthropic endeavors without immediately having to make a final decision on where their donations will end up.

"A lot of donors prefer this because they might have good years and bad years financially, and so when they're having a really great year, they make extra charitable gifts," Vance-McMullen said. "They may not know at the time where they want those gifts to go."

Donor-advised funds have grown significantly in recent years as a method for philanthropy. In 2025, Fidelity Charitable, one of the largest providers of donor-advised funds, reported more than $18 billion in grants through the program—the most in its history.

"It's not uncommon for universities to have DAFs, especially the more well-resourced universities with bigger donor bases and more sophisticated fundraising programs," Vance-McMullen said. "So Columbia would fit in that bucket."

Still, interest in University-sponsored donor-advised funds has fallen. Columbia currently maintains 17 donor-advised fund accounts which hold a combined $20 million, down from a peak of $55 million in 2018. Vance-McMullen told Spectator that the bureaucratic administration required for a University to maintain the program was sometimes overly intensive, decreasing interest.

"It was definitely a thing 10 years ago and 15 years ago, and now some universities find them to be more trouble than they're worth," Vance-McMullen said.

simon.leton
@columbiaspectator.com

How Columbia helped Abdul El-Sayed, VP&S ’14, turn health equity into a political mission

BY ELLIOT HEATH
Staff Writer

In a heated debate on Oct. 8 amid the Senate race in battleground Michigan, Republican candidate Mike Rogers accused Democrat Abdul El-Sayed, VP&S ’14, of being a fake doctor.

“If somebody came into his office and he tried to treat that patient, he’d go to jail,” Rogers said.

“Look, I have a medical degree from Columbia University,” El-Sayed shot back. “If he’s got issues with my credentials, he can take it up with them.”

Indeed, before El-Sayed won the Democratic nomination for one of Michigan’s Senate seats, he earned a doctorate of medicine at the Vagelos College of Physicians and Surgeons and became an assistant professor at the Mailman School of Public Health, where he quickly became known for his thoughtful engagement with peers, five of his former colleagues at Columbia told Spectator.

In an interview with Spectator, the candidate, who has now been thrust into the national spotlight, said that it was at Columbia where he witnessed the systemic inequities in healthcare that would go on to color his life’s work and his campaign.

“The city of New York was a great place to train,” El-Sayed told Spectator. “But it was also a reminder just of how much inequity there really is.”

Before coming to Columbia, El-Sayed graduated from the University of Michigan with high distinction and got his doctorate in public health from the University of Oxford as a Rhodes scholar. He returned to Michigan to study medicine, but transferred to Columbia in 2012 after receiving the Paul and Daisy Soros Fellowship for New Americans, which gave him the opportunity to pursue an M.D. as well as a Ph.D. in epidemiology.

But El-Sayed chose not to pursue residency upon completing his M.D. Instead, he turned to scholarship, looking for big-picture solutions in the medical system through his studies in epidemiology as an assistant professor at Mailman.

“I made a decision not to pursue a clinical residency when I was a student at VP&S in part just because of the insane disparity in terms of the experience of somebody from the local community coming into our emergency room versus somebody flying in from abroad to get a heart procedure,” El-Sayed said. “And I learned a lot about just how much our public health system can do—and too often is not well-equipped to do—and just how difficult it is to address a lot of those systemic issues from inside the clinic.”

Now, more than a decade later, El-Sayed has risen from a decorated public health scholar to a ubiquitous candidate for the U.S. Senate, vying for an open seat that has become key to Democrats’ midterm strategy.

“The guy who used to have the office next to me is on the front page of The New York Times,” Katherine Keyes, Public Health ’06, Public Health ’10, a professor at Mailman’s epidemiology department and a mentor and collaborator of El-Sayed’s, said.

ABDUL EL-SAYED CAMPAIGN / COURTESY OF

COLUMBIA TO CAMPAIGN | “The guy who used to have the office next to me is on the front page of The New York Times,” Katherine Keyes, Public Health ’06, Public Health ’10, a former mentor and collaborator to El-Sayed, said.

MEDICINE AT COLUMBIA

El-Sayed’s focus on inequity in the healthcare industry, now central to his candidate platform, was apparent to many who worked with him at Columbia years ago.

“He could really see what the gaps and the cracks in the whole system were,” Keyes said. “That really came through even at the doctoral level. You could really see that this is someone who can see the entire picture in ways that were really forward-looking.”

El-Sayed’s holistic approach toward medicine made him a standout researcher, his colleagues said. Epidemiologists study changes in health and disease across populations, prompting deeper dives into the factors that cause widespread problems rather than just the problems themselves.

El-Sayed became an assistant professor at Mailman in 2014 after an accelerated hiring process. At the time, applicants typically needed to have completed a postdoctoral fellowship and have secured research funding first. But El-Sayed’s research and eagerness for collaboration were sufficient for the hiring committee, according to Lisa Bates, associate professor at Mailman and a past colleague of El-Sayed’s.

“He was engaged as a scholar in a very significant way, far and beyond, I think, what a typical person at his career stage, a typical trainee would look like,” Bates said.

El-Sayed stayed active throughout his time at Mailman, serving as one of several Columbia health experts the University tasked with communicating with the media and the public about the Ebola virus outbreak in 2014. He developed a course alongside Bates and the department’s curriculum committee on systems science and population health, which he later taught.

Aside from his résumé, colleagues and mentors reminisced about El-Sayed’s sense of humor and affability.

“When we were having these different groups and events, Abdul was someone who just was lighting up the room with a joke and a smile and mentoring other people and helping other students,” Keyes said.

“Any advice we gave, he considered carefully, he gave us counters, we discussed it,” Michael Shelanski, then-director of the Medical Scientist Training Program, said. “He’s super smart and super perceptive in dealing with people. So I mean, he fell in the group of students I really enjoyed interacting with. ... He was among the best of them.”

El-Sayed transferred to Vagelos from Michigan shortly after his longtime mentor and former professor Sandro Galea, Public Health ’03, became chair of Mailman’s epidemiology department.

In early 2015, Galea left Columbia to start a position at Boston University. The epidemiology department concocted a goodbye present for him: a home video in the mockumentary style of “The Office,” which featured satirical testimonials from faculty members.

“What is the most important lesson that Sandro has taught me?” El-Sayed riffed in the video’s cold open, showing off his haircut to the screen. “It’s that an olive-complexioned man with a precise side part can get really far in epidemiology.”

By the time the parody video was released, El-Sayed had known Galea for a better part of a decade. The two began working together when El-Sayed was an undergraduate, and they continued to co-author dozens of papers as he moved on to Oxford and later to medical school.

“Abdul was always what he is today—deeply passionate about health and what he could do to improve the health of populations,” Galea wrote to Spectator.

A MICHIGAN HOMECOMING

El-Sayed’s stint at Mailman was brief but seminal.

He was on the faculty for about a year and a half until August 2015 when he moved back to Michigan to serve as the executive director of the Detroit Health Department.

In Shelanski’s experience running the M.D.-Ph.D. track at Vagelos, “some of our very, very best graduates from the program actually never practice medicine. They become the leading authorities in the fields.”

Columbia set El-Sayed on a public-facing path. At only 30 years old, he was tasked not only to run Detroit’s health department, but rebuild it after the city filed for bankruptcy and delegated the agency’s services to a private nonprofit. It was a hefty role, but it was one that allowed him to put his epidemiological research to practice.

“A lot of the work that I did was about systems and understanding the way that systems drive outcomes,” El-Sayed said. “You see that in public health all the time, and a lot of my work was about building a department or leading departments to try to address structural failures.”

Outside the health director role, El-Sayed continued to build a professional profile. He was named “Public Official of the Year” by the Michigan League of Conservation Voters and received a Bicentennial Alumni Award at the University of Michigan’s 2017 spring commencement. He also published his first book, “Systems Science and Population Health,” which he edited with Galea.

With new momentum, El-Sayed pivoted to politics when he ran for Michigan governor in 2018. While he would ultimately lose the Democratic primary, his progressive campaign attracted endorsements from prominent figures like Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.) and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-N.Y.).

More than a decade prior, on the day of his graduation from the University of Michigan, El-Sayed said, former President Bill Clinton told El-Sayed, a student speaker for the ceremony, that he should consider running for office someday.

“Ten years on, I was like, ‘All right, you know what? This guy got elected, maybe I could do it,’” El-Sayed said.

Colleagues said El-Sayed’s shift to campaigning made sense.

“It felt ambitious, consistent with his ambition generally,” Steve Mooney, Public Health ’12, Public Health ’16, a longtime friend and frequent collaborator of El-Sayed’s in the epidemiology department, said. “It was easy to see why politics would be a good calling for him. He connects with people very naturally.”

All the while, global cataclysms like the COVID-19 pandemic put healthcare issues center stage. El-Sayed commented on politics and the healthcare industry via a podcast he started in 2019 called America Dissected while serving as health director of Wayne County, which houses Detroit, beginning in 2023.

Two years later, at the dawn of President Donald Trump’s second term, El-Sayed saw an opportunity he couldn’t ignore.

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL

One week into the second Trump administration, incumbent Sen. Gary Peters (D-Mich.) announced he would not run for reelection, setting the stage for a highly contested race to replace him.

At the same time, the federal government announced it would pause hundreds of billions of dollars in federal grants, sparking alarm across the healthcare industry, though it rescinded the pause two days later.

“It was literally the day that they had froze federal funds, and I’m sitting in Wayne County trying to make sure WIC checks go out, that federally qualified health centers don’t get shut down, that vaccines keep going into arms,” El-Sayed told Spectator. “I realized, look, we need to carry the fight for the public’s health to the U.S. Senate.”

Right from the start of his Senate campaign on April 17, 2025, Medicare for All—a single-payer system proposal—emerged as one of his signature campaign policies.

To friends and mentors, El-Sayed’s stance on universal healthcare reflects values he has held since he was an epidemiology student—that addressing systemic inequities is the key to spurring real change in populations. Five years after he left Mailman, El-Sayed co-wrote a book on the subject.

“I think his platform related to Medicare for All is based on the fundamental insight that health is a human right,” Bates said. “It’s true to his values about caring about public health overall for all people, regardless of their stature in life.”

Recent polls from Ipsos and KFF show anywhere from 43 percent to a firm majority of Americans favor Medicare for All. However, only a minority of Congress members are in favor, with numerous bills to implement the proposal failing to pass in recent years as the policy divides the Democratic establishment.

El-Sayed has nonetheless emerged as a near-ubiquitous force in American politics in the last several months. He narrowly beat Rep. Haley Stevens (D-Mich.), a moderate, to secure the Democratic nomination in early August, and his ongoing race against Rogers is key for Democrats to regain control of the Senate in November.

As Trump’s policies continue to affect Columbia and higher education as a whole, El-Sayed criticized his alma mater for its “cowardly” deal with the Trump administration.

The University struck a landmark deal with the Trump administration in July 2025, agreeing to pay $221 million to restore grant funding the government had canceled over allegations of antisemitic harassment at Columbia.

“The deal was such a disaster on two terms,” El-Sayed told Spectator. “Number one, watching the federal government bully an institution of higher learning, quite contrary to the free speech rights that the institution had, and then watching the institution take it rather than fight back.”

Columbia has previously defended the decision to settle, arguing that the deal maintains the University’s independence and continues prior efforts to combat antisemitism on campus.

The deal came amid intense national scrutiny over Columbia’s handling of pro-Palestinian activists on campus who have demanded that Columbia divest from companies tied to Israel on account of the country’s military actions in Gaza.

“When I think about my institutions that I went to,” El-Sayed said, “if they chose to divest from a government that is perpetrating genocide, perpetrating apartheid and has pushed for war, I think that’s completely consistent with the values of those universities.”

A Columbia spokesperson declined to comment.

El-Sayed joins a cadre of rising progressive candidates—including Mayor Zohran Mamdani and Darializa Avila Chevalier, CC ’16, the Democratic nominee for New York’s 13th Congressional District, both with ties to Columbia—who are challenging the political status quo across the country. All have championed pro-Palestinian stances that have historically been taboo in American politics.

El-Sayed’s criticisms of Israel’s actions in Gaza, where Israeli forces have killed at least 74,000 Palestinians according to Gaza’s Health Ministry, have drawn accusations of antisemitism. Those who worked closely with him at Columbia, however, rejected that characterization.

“I have a firm commitment—I’ve got to say this carefully—to the existence of an Israeli state, though I have no commitment at all to the existence of the current Israeli government,” Shelanski, who is Jewish, told Spectator. “And obviously Abdul comes from the position of having a family from Egypt, of seeing things from the Arab perspective. I never had the feeling that he was in the least bit antisemitic.”

If elected, El-Sayed would be the first Muslim senator. Some of the public attacks against El-Sayed have veered into Islamophobic rhetoric. He and Bates had the chance to speak early in El-Sayed’s primary campaign when he visited New York City. They briefly discussed what Bates called the “Mamdani effect,” which she defines as an increased alarm from the opposition in response to Muslim politicians’ successes.

“His commitments are really clear. I think he is really, really committed to doing this important work,” Bates said of El-Sayed. “It gives him this kind of superpower endurance to push through all of that and to persevere in this cloud of misinformation and hate, deflection.”

Beside religion and politics, El-Sayed and Mamdani share another critical strategy in common: a knack for social media. Mamdani rose in part due to his campaign’s sleekly produced videos touting his policies, a practice he has continued into his mayoralty.

El-Sayed, with a history of being on camera and six years of podcasting experience under his belt, was quick to add a creative flair to his Senate campaign. In one video, he explains wealth inequality using a cheeseburger. In another, he spoofs the dating reality show “Love Island” to introduce himself.

The videos have helped El-Sayed gain a national audience, especially with younger people.

“I have to say I’m not a millennial and some of the videos of late for the campaign definitely give me a little bit of cringe,” Bates said of El-Sayed’s social media strategy. “But I’m happy to accept I’m not a millennial. This isn’t for me.”

Should El-Sayed be elected, his background in health would make him a unique voice in the Senate, which hasn’t had a Democratic doctor serve since 1969. Politics and medicine are different skills, but a physician’s training, colleagues said, can still guide their values as a lawmaker.

“The Hippocratic Oath and the ‘first, do no harm’—I don’t think you can be a politician without doing harm,” Mooney said. “But centering your choices on thinking about the harms while you’re thinking about the potential benefits is something that I want to have in my policy decision-makers.”

Having known El-Sayed for years, Keyes has seen the confluence of his epidemiological expertise, holistic values, and outgoing personality up close. That fusion has evolved to define much of his campaign and political identity.

“I think it’s a rare combination to have someone with that level of skill and attention to detail and training, but also with the clear gifts that he has of moving people and getting people together and advancing a mission,” Keyes said.

elliot.heath
@columbiaspectator.com

Law School launches new initiative to bolster AI education

BY SIMON LETON
Staff Writer

The Law School announced a new initiative Oct. 14 designed to improve the integration of AI into the student experience.

The initiative, AI @ CLS, consolidates existing efforts to incorporate AI into the school’s curriculum and resources with a set of new programs, including the introduction of new faculty, academic courses, and AI tools, supported by a partnership with Paul, Weiss, Rifkind, Wharton & Garrison, a prominent global law firm.

“AI presents an extraordinary opportunity to bridge our proud tradition of rigorous, theoretical education with the realities of modern legal practice,” Daniel Abebe, dean of the Law School and the Lucy G. Moses professor of law, said in a press release announcing the initiative.

In interviews with Spectator, law students expressed a diversity of opinions about AI. However, they largely agreed the school should implement changes like the new initiative to keep up as technology advances.

The initiative comes a year after the Law School established a task force on AI to evaluate the school’s approach to education. Talia Gillis, co-chair of the task force and the Daniel G. Ross professor of law, explained in an interview with Spectator that the task force has since worked to incorporate the perspectives of students, faculty, and professionals.

“We were very interested in hearing from law firms and lawyers in the public sector and public-interest sector about how they were encountering AI,” Gillis said, noting that the task force worked to understand how the technology was impacting junior lawyers in particular so the school could implement a more effective set of initiatives.

As part of the changes, the Law School has announced a new upper-level elective, Law & AI, taught by Gillis and Eric Talley, the Marc and Eva Stern professor of law and business, which designed to explore the interaction between AI and the legal field.

“We wanted to foster an environment in which there weren’t these a priori, dogmatic opinions about AI being good or bad, but really learning the technology, understanding it, thinking through its limitations, and being critical in that respect,” Gillis said.

The Law School is also incorporating AI literacy efforts into its Legal Practice Workshop, a required course for first-year J.D. students. Rebecca Wexler, the Alfred W. Bressler professor of law, and Gillis are designing new AI modules that other professors could incorporate into their courses.

Gillis emphasized that a core goal was to maintain intellectual independence and preserve students’ ability to think freely, without falling out of touch with the technology.

“The idea is that you always maintain that kind of intellectual ownership and your own judgment over anything you do,” Gillis explained. “The biggest risk is when you substitute that judgment and that intellectual ownership to AI.”

Jayden Lee, Law ’27, told Spectator he had encountered AI extensively in his work as a summer associate at a law firm—far more than he had in his courses at the Law School.

“For most of my assignments, I was instructed to use AI software like Harvey, and there are other AI tools made by the law firm itself,” Lee said.

As part of the new initiative, the Law School is making two new professional AI platforms, Harvey and Legora, available to students to assist with legal research, document creation, and workflow automation.

In August, the Law School released its 2026-27 AI policy, which gives professors broad latitude to use AI in their courses to whatever extent they prefer.

“At the Law School, the pedagogical control of a course is a key element of the way we teach, and so you wouldn’t want AI to be an exception to that,” Gillis said.

Students told Spectator that AI policies took drastically different forms across their courses.

“It varies a lot,” Gustavo Chamadoiro, Law ’27, a master of laws student, said, adding that in one of his courses, AI was strictly prohibited. “On the other hand, in Legal Research and Writing, the professor allows us to use AI even to correct our writing and to generate our writing.”

The initiative also includes a five-year commitment from Paul, Weiss, which will help to support the development of new curricular offerings, an expansion of faculty research, and programming which will bring legal professionals to campus. Elliott Ash, Law ’10, GSAS ’16, an associate professor at ETH Zurich, will join the faculty as the inaugural Paul, Weiss Distinguished AI Scholar in Residence, according to the announcement.

“We are proud to partner with Columbia Law to help empower the next generation of lawyers to be in a position to use AI effectively, creatively, and responsibly after they graduate,” Paul, Weiss chairman Scott Barshay, Law ’91, said in the release.

Paul, Weiss, like Columbia, reached a controversial deal with President Donald Trump’s administration in 2025, after choosing to negotiate rather than sue over cuts to contracts and revocations of security clearances. As part of the deal, the firm agreed to provide more than $40 million in pro bono legal services to the federal government and end diversity, equity, and inclusion policies.

While some students Spectator spoke with expressed that they had not yet heard about the initiative, all recognized that AI is an increasingly important technology and acknowledged a need for more institutional support around it.

“Honestly, it’s happening so quickly that a lot of our professors aren’t even prepared to prepare us for how fast things are changing,” Rachel Krul, BC ’23, Law ’28, said.

Despite the unclear trajectory for AI’s adoption in the legal field, Gillis expressed confidence in the University’s approach.

“There is a lot of uncertainty,” Gillis said, “but I guess there’s one thing I can say fairly confidently, that not engaging is probably not the way forward.”

simon.leton
@columbiaspectator.com

Students offer alternative campus access through 'The People's Kiosk,' critiquing Columbia kiosk

BY USHOSHI DAS
& FRANKA ETKIN
Columbia Daily Spectator

ELIZA LAMSTER / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

ACCESS GRANTED | Over the course of the evening, "The People Kiosk" registered 30 guests.

Students gathered in front of Columbia's locked campus gates on Oct. 18th, setting up a folding table on Broadway and 116th Street — "The People's Kiosk."

"Do you want to get on campus?" students tabling called out to passersby.

Signs in front of the table laid out instructions for how to access campus as a guest: "Step 1 make a friend," "Step 2 get a qr code," and "Step 3 come inside."

Over the course of the evening, students used the guest registration form to sign in 30 guests who gained access to Columbia's campus, according to emailed QR codes obtained by Spectator.

The alternative form of campus access comes as the gates have been intermittently closed to the public since October 2023, fueling ongoing disputes over public access to Columbia's campus. The name is a spin-off of the University's Access Service Kiosk, which was launched on Oct. 1. The kiosk is intended to address the gate closures by providing community members with information about accessing campus, but has since drawn criticism for its location behind the locked gates.

"It's both damning and telling that the kiosk that Columbia set up is inside the campus gates, and I think it is equally telling and significant that the one that we set up is outside of them," Josh Cohen, CC '28, a spokesperson for Columbia University Tenants' Union, which organized the kiosk, said.

As students tabled outside the gates, others were setting up for Columbia Chinese Students Club's Night Market within the gates. The market is an annual campus tradition featuring student performances and cultural dishes, and it took place Oct. 18 from 6 to 10 p.m. on Low Plaza.

Cohen said that while community members have historically attended the night market, they have not been able to since the University restricted public access, adding, "We think they should have access to community events like that."

"The University is working toward a more open campus that balances safety with the engagement, exchange and openness central to our academic mission and our identity as part of New York City," a University spokesperson wrote in a statement to Spectator. "As part of that effort, Columbia already offers eligible neighborhood residents free, ongoing campus access through its Campus Access for Neighbors program."

A University official told Spectator that 1,427 community members have access to campus through the program. The official added that students are responsible for any guests they sign onto campus.

Cohen said that the students helping with sign-ins represented a group of "concerned students and community members." He said they were filling out Columbia's guest registration form because Columbia has "failed to ensure" that the University's neighbors have access to campus.

"We've taken it upon ourselves as students to grant them access," Cohen said.

As of September, Barnard and Teachers College students may sign in two same-day guests every day, while Columbia College, School of Engineering and Applied Science, and School of General Studies students can sign in five same-day guests.

The updated guest access policy went into place Sept. 8, the first day of fall semester classes, following an email from University President Jennifer Mnookin, which outlined a three-pronged plan to address limited campus access.

Previously, all students could only sign in two same-day guests.

Cohen told Spectator that the kiosk's presence follows Mayor Zohran Mamdani's threat to sue Columbia over the gates, as well as years of pressure from community groups.

The Morningside Heights Community Coalition has protested the gate closures five times in the last three years.

Mary Bacon, a resident of Morningside Heights who lives across the street from the Morningside campus, received a QR code from "The People's Kiosk" despite having an existing QR code provided for certain neighborhood residents.

Bacon said she does not remember the last time she went on campus.

"I just don't bother," Bacon said. "It doesn't feel welcoming, and I don't really want to."

Bacon referred to the campus as a previous "recreation area" for the neighborhood, saying that her kids celebrated Halloween on Columbia's campus during the COVID-19 pandemic. Bacon said that prior to the gate closures, she used to walk her dogs on campus at night because "it's safe" and "contained," unlike the parks surrounding the area.

Bacon said she holds numerous ties to campus through her family members despite having never attended the University. Her husband's funeral was on campus at St. Paul's Chapel.

"I'm someone who would like to go see the chapel often," she told Spectator.

Despite this, Bacon also said that having to go through checkpoints to access campus "doesn't feel good."

Other community members, like Annick Billet, also gained campus access through "The People's Kiosk." Billet has lived on 122nd Street for the last 15 years, and as a neighbor and former Barnard parent, Billet feels she has "the right" to access the campus.

"One of my daughters went to Barnard many years ago, and we feel like we have the right, after all the tuition we pay, that we should be able to use the campus, and also because we are neighbors and we pay a lot of taxes, so I think we deserve a right as a New York citizen," she said.

Billet said that the last time she was on campus was during the COVID-19 pandemic.

"We could come and have a coffee, and we read a book, and enjoy fresh air and the beautiful flowers and bushes," she said.

Paul Dana, another Morningside Heights resident, said he was not expecting to be greeted by the students at "The People's Kiosk". When approached by a student who asked him if he wanted a guest access pass, Dana noted how the kiosk reminded him of the fragility of institutional memory.

"I thought it's a great thing that students are actually out there talking about this, because I've met students who almost really didn't know that it had ever been open by this point," Dana said. "Or if they knew, they knew it, but it was like folklore."

Dana told Spectator that his frustration stems from the inconvenience of accessing transit and other neighborhood institutions, for example, by not being able to directly access Mount Sinai Morningside hospital and the 116th Street–Columbia University station, by no longer being able to take classes on campus, and simply by the fact that as a lifelong neighbor, he "always liked walking around there."

Multiple people who got their QR codes at the people's kiosk were visitors to New York City.

Andrew Pugliese, a student at the University of Toronto doing an internship in New York City, told Spectator he "wasn't sure" whether he could enter Columbia's campus, adding, "I saw the opportunity, and it's awesome."

Some visitors were not expecting to be met with closed gates.

"We didn't know, actually. We were told on the other side of the gates, because last time I came here was like four years ago, and we were able to get in with my friends and to check it around," Tomas Hvala, a University of Virginia student visiting New York with his parents, said.

Gabriel Nava, a first-time visitor, found the closed campus "really strange," since he had freely accessed another university before.

According to Cohen, the students hope to make the people's kiosk a recurring event.

"People should take away from this that the student body stands with the community," Cohen said. "There's overwhelming support for the gates being opened, and that we're ready to take action into our own hands."

ushoshi.das
@columbiaspectator.com

franka.etkin
@columbiaspectator.com

Manhattanville Houses transfers property management amid resident concerns about ongoing repairs

BY AIYANA ST. HILAIRE
Deputy News Editor

JACKSON DILKS / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

UNDER NEW MANAGEMENT | After nearly two years of alleged oversight by ELH Management, Manhattanville will now be overseen by Wavecrest Management.

Manhattanville Houses, a public housing project which includes six apartment buildings between West 129th and 133rd Street, first transitioned from public to privatized housing in December 2024 following a $445 million settlement. Now, nearly two years later, the company managing the privatization is changing, with Wavecrest Management replacing ELH Management on Oct. 1.

The change comes after residents have reported an array of challenges, including water and gas issues, under ELH Management.

A representative from the New York City Housing Authority wrote in a statement to Spectator that a more experienced organization managing Permanent Affordability Commitment Together sites is important in a place like Manhattanville. The turnover was informed by a property management performance test monitored by Gilbane Development, a designated PACT partner, the representative wrote.

The challenges have prompted continuous resident frustration with the former management company. For nearly a month in October 2025, hundreds of Manhattanville residents were left without gas or clean water while management addressed repairs.

A representative from ELH Management shared that complaints regarding Manhattanville should not automatically be attributed to the property manager, as ELH Management is not the owner of Manhattanville Houses.

Some residents in Manhattanville are already wary of its successor, Wavecrest Management. The property management company, based in Richmond Hill, has operated for more than 40 years and owns hundreds of private buildings in its portfolio.

Tenants, housing lawyers, and whistleblowers have previously spoken about Wavecrest Management's reputation for "mismanagement," as its properties have been associated with a Legionnaires outbreak, according to amNewYork, as well as lack of repairs following a building explosion, WPIX reported.

"I don't really want anybody like Wavecrest to come in and take over for ELH if they're worse than ELH," Paul Ortiz, a Manhattanville Houses resident of over 50 years, said in an interview with Spectator.

Wavecrest Management did not respond to repeated requests for comment.

Previously, ELH Management oversaw Manhattanville through PACT's Rental Assistance Demonstration program, formed in 2012. This allowed NYCHA to convert Section 9 public housing into project-based Section 8 vouchers—effectively handing over public housing leases to private landlords.

Manhattanville residents have had mixed experiences under the owner-manager company, which has three decades of experience in affordable housing.

"ELH has so many lawsuits and complaints against them with different branches of government, that I would not be surprised if they get fired, if their contract gets canceled out or terminated," Ortiz said.

A representative for ELH Management disputed Ortiz's characterization, noting that complaints, violations, or legal proceedings involving a property are not necessarily actions against its management company.

Gilbane Development Company, West Harlem Group Assistance, and Apex Building Group, informed residents of the property management transition on Sept. 21, according to a letter to tenants obtained by Spectator. PACT partners told residents they would receive a transition package before Oct. 1, including a letter from NYCHA and information from Wavecrest Management.

"Under PACT, property management partners are responsible for the day-to-day operation and upkeep of the buildings and grounds," a NYCHA spokesperson wrote in a statement to Spectator.

Lydia Gonzalez, a resident of Manhattanville Houses since 2014, said that she felt "scared" about the future of the housing project due to the transfer. Gonzalez feared that the recent management turnover would mark the beginning of residents being forced out of Manhattanville Houses.

A NYCHA representative informed Spectator that Manhattanville's resident association board was notified of the change of building management in September and met regularly with Wavecrest Management ahead of the transition.

Residents say communication has been disjointed among building leadership.

"You talk to these different supervisors of these different groups, APEX, Gilbane and PACT, so on and so forth. They're not all on the same page, they don't even communicate with each other like you think they would," Ortiz said.

Despite changes in property management, repairs that began in December 2024 still continue throughout Manhattanville. Renovations will provide the buildings with new energy-efficient heating and hot water systems, fully modernized elevators, and additional common areas.

While Manhattanville residents settle into new building management and face complications with continued repairs, NYCHA still retains building ownership.

"NYCHA did not and is not selling Manhattanville Houses. As of December 2024 it is included in the PACT program which means that the apartments, building infrastructure and community spaces will receive millions of dollars of investment to improve quality of life for Manhattanville residents," a NYCHA spokesperson wrote in a statement to Spectator.

At the end of September, Ortiz relocated to another building while repairs and construction continued in his unit, he said.

Gonzalez has witnessed the building navigate numerous property managers and privatization over a decade. As Gonzalez awaits relocation to a new apartment as repairs continue, she and her 23-year-old daughter face the difficulty of their new apartment being too small.

"They accepted me for two bedrooms and then later when they came, now I have one bedroom," she said.

Gonzalez said she is planning on sleeping in the living room so her daughter can still have her own room. Her other four children who lived in Manhattanville Houses have left the building because of its need for repairs.

"My kids, they used to live with me, five, and right now, it's me and my daughter," Gonzalez said.

Despite continued problems in Manhattanville, Gonzalez does not want to leave West Harlem.

"We have to fight for all these things," Gonzalez said.

aiyana.sthilaire
@columbiaspectator.com

Manhattan Immigration Welcome Center opens in West Harlem

BY FRANKA ETKIN
News Deputy Editor

ELIZA LAMSTER / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

LEGAL AID | The center is open from 9 a.m. to 5 p.m., Monday through Friday.

The Manhattan Immigrant Welcome Center opened its doors in West Harlem on Sept. 29, offering services to connect immigrants with legal aid and healthcare.

The center, located at 431 W. 125th St., describes itself as a direct response to Donald Trump's administration targeting immigrants in cities across the country. Immigration and Customs Enforcement arrests in New York City increased by 71 percent in the first 15 months of the Trump administration, compared to the last 15 months of the Biden administration, according to a May 2026 audit by the mayor's office. On Oct. 8, the shooting of Marble Hill resident Oscar Belgal provoked outrage from New Yorkers, who flooded the streets calling for the abolition of ICE.

Amid the citywide uptick in ICE presence, Manhattan Borough President Brad Hoylman-Sigal announced the opening of the Immigrant Welcome Center in late September. The center will work in tandem with various volunteer organizations including New York Legal Assistance Group, New York Cares, and Cabrini Immigrant Services to provide legal and health services to immigrant community members.

The center has served over 70 constituents seeking its services in its first three weeks of operation, according to Holyman-Sigal. At the ribbon cutting ceremony, he said the welcome center was inspired by the Queens Immigrant Welcome Center, opened by Queens Borough President Donovan Richards in summer 2021. Hoylman-Sigal noted that, in addition to being the site of the borough president's northern Manhattan office, West Harlem is a historically immigrant-rich community.

"Harlem has historically served as a melting pot for immigrants of different cultures for decades, including Puerto Rican, West African, and other immigrant communities," Hoylman-Sigal wrote in a statement to Spectator. "Immigrants have contributed to Harlem's evolving cultural identity seeking opportunity and belonging, making it a meaningful place for a center dedicated to helping immigrant New Yorkers navigate life in the city."

Thirty-four percent of West Harlem's population is "foreign-born," according to data collected by the U.S. Census Bureau.

"What makes our community rich in diversity is our immigrant community," Holyman-Sigal said at the Sept. 29 ribbon-cutting ceremony for the center.

In 2024, Trump promised to launch "the largest domestic deportation operation" as part of his presidential campaign,and he has specifically targeted sanctuary cities such as Los Angeles, Chicago, and New York City since assuming office.

"In the face of Donald Trump's lawless targeting of immigrants, Upper Manhattan has seen neighbors from across the community come together hand-in-hand to protect the rights of those most vulnerable," City Council Majority Leader Shaun Abreu, CC '14, wrote in the press release.

Over the summer, the New York Immigration Coalition reported an increase in ICE presence in northern Manhattan, including the neighborhoods of Washington Heights and Inwood. Federal agents have been reported as impersonating construction workers and police officers in order to perform arrests.

"Manhattan is central to ICE's campaign and presence in the City," Hoylman-Sigal wrote in his statement.

New York Legal Assistance Group, one of the organizations which will partner with the center, is a nonprofit organization that provides free civil legal assistance to New Yorkers in need. The organization will bring its "Mobile Legal Help Clinic" van to the center monthly to provide residents with "information, resources, and access to justice," according to Lisa Rivera, the organization's CEO and president. The services of the Manhattan Immigration Welcome Center are not limited to recent immigrants.

"We are proud to forge this vital partnership and ultimately make legal services accessible whether someone arrived yesterday or over a decade ago," Rivera wrote in a statement to Spectator.

For Hoylman-Sigal, the center aims to aid immigrants navigating social service systems.

"With so many rules shifting, families need someone who can give them accurate answers in their language about their rights and which resources are available to them," the borough president wrote. "Our staff can help eligible New Yorkers enroll in social services resources such as food assistance and in NYC Care, which provides free to low-cost medical care regardless of immigration status."

Javier Ramirez Baron, executive director of Cabrini Immigrant Services, a nonprofit that provides free legal and social services to immigrants across New York City, believes that the welcome center is timely and significant.

"Especially for the time that we live in right now, and in my opinion, our community living here, the community needs to hear from the elected officials that they are working with," Ramirez Baron said.

According to Ramirez Baron, Cabrini has a history of working in collaboration with the borough president's office, but the recent partnership between the welcome center and his offices has brought "more referrals, especially for people who want to have a lawyer or a creditory representative to review the cases."

"I'm proud that so many immigrant New Yorkers already know about our Immigrant welcome center, and encourage all New Yorkers to take advantage of the free legal, casework, and social services assistance our office can provide," Hoylman-Sigal wrote.

franka.etkin
@columbiaspectator.com

Columbia's closed gates hurt foot traffic, disrupt deliveries, local businesses say

BY FRANCESCA MORENO & EVIN SCHWARTZ
Columbia Daily Spectator

GABY DIAZ / SENIOR STAFF PHOTOGRAPHER

BUSINESSES BURNED | Since the spring 2024 "Gaza Solidarity Encampment," the University gates have been closed, barring a brief period in summer 2024.

Local businesses along Broadway and Amsterdam Avenue say they have been hurt by Columbia's yearslong gate closures, reporting lost customers, costly delivery challenges, and declining neighborhood morale.

Andy Garcia, a former manager of The Heights Bar and Grill who currently works at Amity Hall Uptown, said that the closed campus and increased security on and around campus have dampened the neighborhood's liveliness, leading to fewer customers.

"It's gotten worse since the closure, just because it's two different social groups, two different ways of life. But there's definitely been a divide," Garcia said.

The gates have been closed since the spring 2024 "Gaza Solidarity Encampment," barring a brief period that summer 2024. While Columbia has offered programs to expand access—including one that grants nearby residents campus access via a QR code—many remain shut out of campus.

The prolonged closures have sparked debate over the University's commitment to the public good and have led to an ongoing lawsuit. For nearby businesses, the closures have quietly reshaped their operations, leading to lower morale among patrons and an increased divide between locals and students, according to several businesses who spoke to Spectator.

The restrictions have challenged local businesses like Samad's Gourmet and V&T Pizzeria and Restaurant, whose owners shared setbacks in delivering to campus.

Sujit Balachandran—a partner at Roti Roll, a counter-service Indian wrap joint, and Suite, a neighboring gay bar and lounge—said that his restaurant caters frequently to Columbia students. Delivery drivers now have to stand outside the gates and wait, and sometimes they cannot contact the person who placed the order, he said.

"That costs us money, because then the delivery guy has to stand there and hang out until the person is reached," Balachandran said.

Cody Madsen, vice president of operations at Book Culture, described the contrast between coordinating book deliveries before the closures and now.

"Even today, I'm gonna be doing a delivery on campus, and it only took probably six or seven extra back-and-forth emails to make sure that I would have clearance, so I would be able to do the drop-off this evening," Madsen said.

Madsen added that in past years, they would be able to "walk in on campus and be able to get to the professor's office or department office for deliveries and drop-offs."

The University is "already working toward a more open campus," according to a University spokesperson, who wrote in a statement to Spectator that it is looking to balance "our responsibility to protect those who study, teach, work and live on campus with the engagement, exchange and openness that help us fulfill our academic mission and promote the community that is at the heart of our identity as part of New York City."

For Madsen, the gate closures' restriction to invited scholars and guest speakers has cut into the bookstore's customer base.

"Talking to people who've organized events on campus, I think they've seen a very noticeable decline in attendance for those events," Madsen said.

With fewer people able to attend these events, fewer potential customers are coming to Book Culture to purchase books published or discussed by the speakers. The gates have "fractured" the neighborhood, Madsen said.

Faith Ethridge, a barista and manager at Hex&Co, a board game café, echoed the sentiment. During her first year as an employee, she was able to visit the campus during her breaks and enjoy the lively atmosphere surrounded by people similar in age as her, she said. Now, she feels that the campus has become inaccessible.

"There just feels like there is a little bit more of a wall," Ethridge said. "It just feels less like I can enter their world, but they're very easily able to enter this one."

University President Jennifer Mnookin acknowledged the divide between Columbia and the neighboring community, in light of the closed gates, in an interview with Spectator last month.

"I do think this is an extremely important moment for us to be looking at local and to ask, 'What does it mean to be Columbia University in the City of New York?'" Mnookin said. "How can we be good neighbors? How can we make a difference? We should be asking all of these questions."

Garcia added that he saw a "massive decrease" at The Heights as students turned to other bars and establishments downtown.

"Students weren't sticking around as much. They were going elsewhere," he said. "They didn't really want to hang out in the area. Kind of an air of non-welcoming."

This is not the first time that Columbia's gate closures have hurt local commerce. A 1972 article published by Spectator detailed how the closure of the gates between Hartley Hall and Livingston, now known as Wallach Hall, led to a significant decrease in student patronage to local businesses on Amsterdam Avenue, with some reporting declines as high as 75 percent.

In one interview with the owner of a local laundromat, Irving Cannon remarked that "students are our livelihood" and "once they closed that gate, it was our death knell."

For businesses within Columbia's gates, the closures have directly impacted employees. Nicole Colon, a barista at Joe Coffee Pulitzer, said she has less job security due to slower business.

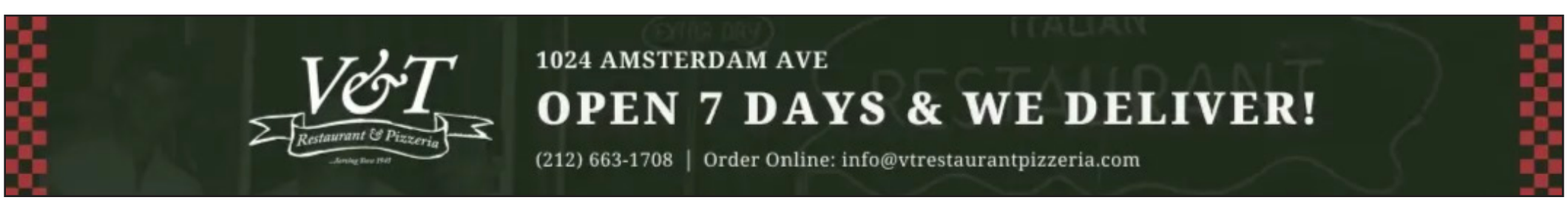
"We don't have as much traffic as we used to, but now with students here, we do make a decent amount of money," Colon said.

Despite the toll the closed gates have taken on Morningside Heights businesses, employees remain optimistic that their efforts to promote their business and maintain visibility will pay off.

"Thankfully, we haven't really seen a decline in terms of students coming in, but part of that is because we work much harder to make sure that that happens," Madsen said.

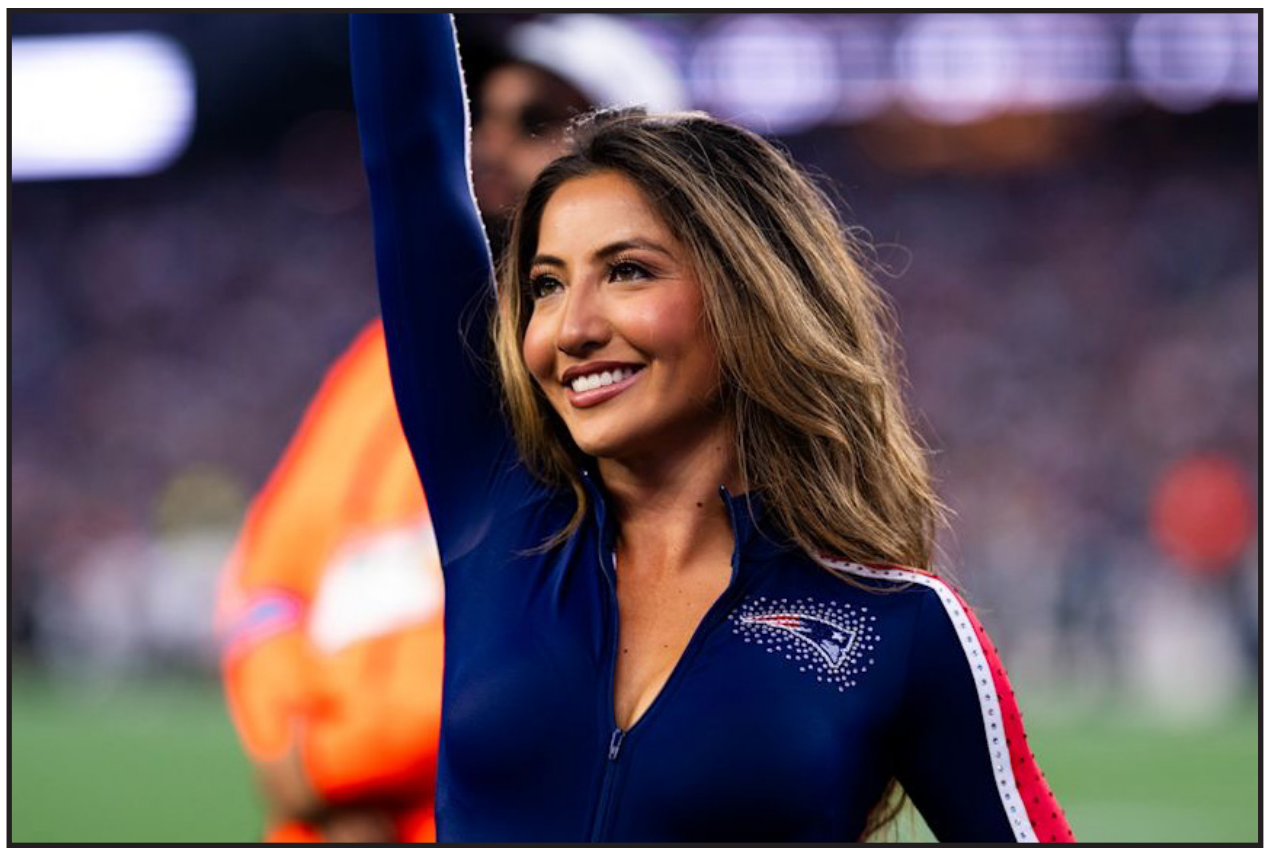
francesca.moreno
@columbiaspectator.com

evin.schwartz
@columbiaspectator.com.



Jade Bucci, CC '25, on cheerleading for the New England Patriots and working a 9-to-5

BY TAYLOR GRAHAM
Arts & Culture Editor



JON RATNER / COURTESY OF

GAME DAY| Bucci cheering on the sidelines at a Patriots game

Coming from a dance background, Jade Bucci, CC '25, first held a pair of pom-poms while performing at a football game as a member of the Columbia University Dance Team. Now, Bucci performs with the colorful tassels regularly as an NFL cheerleader for the New England Patriots.

Bucci began dancing at age five and started competing at six, continuing throughout most of her childhood until her senior year of high school. When she got to college, however, Bucci felt burnt out and decided to take a break from dance—except for her brief time on Columbia's dance team, where she performed at a single football game during her sophomore year.

"I really just wanted to see what my life would look like without dance, because my whole life had been with dance. So I figured it was a time for me to really dive into my academics, see if there was other things I could get involved in, and focus on what I was without it," Bucci said.

But after seeing her friends join their college dance teams and spirit squads, and others go on to become NFL cheerleaders, Bucci started to look into that career path. It was after graduating from Columbia that Bucci began taking dance classes more seriously, training with her coach Dre Dilorenzo. It was Dilorenzo who suggested she look into cheerleading for the Patriots.

The Patriots audition process, Bucci said, involved several rounds, culminating in a final live showcase. One part of the process also included a live interview question tailored to each auditionee. Bucci, who majored in computer science with a concentration in sociology and has an interest in interactions between people and technology, was asked by the evaluating team, "What are your thoughts on the use of AI in the workspace?"

"It is really fun that they highlight and recognize other parts of you besides the performance aspect because we really are doing so much more than just performing on the sidelines," Bucci said. "Everyone always talks about it. It's a part-time job, but it is a full-time commitment."

That commitment started for Bucci when she had to frequently commute between Boston and New York, where her nine-to-five job in operations at a tech startup is based.

"My whole life was still in New York, but then I had this new part of my own life that no longer was. So I was kind of living a double life where I was commuting multiple times a week. It was exhausting, but it was worth it," Bucci said.

When Bucci learned that she made the team, she recalls thinking her entire life was about to change.

"I remember making direct eye contact with my parents in the audience being like, 'Oh, wow, this is the real deal,'" she said.

Coming from dance, the biggest adjustment for Bucci in her transition to cheer was performing with pom-poms and with her hair down. She also had to get used to creating "photo moments," striking powerful poses, and projecting up and out into the stands so that fans sitting as far as in the nosebleeds could feel the energy on the field.

"The movements, it's just different. It's a whole different sort of performance, and there's just different elements that I had never thought about that I had to start thinking about," Bucci said.

Bucci said that any pressure she may feel to bring on the spirit at Gillette Stadium is more "self-inflicted" than it is from the fans, who are "so engaged" and "so excited to be there." For her, cheerleading for the Patriots feels like a "once-in-a-lifetime opportunity."

"There's generations of people that have been Patriots fans, and just being a small piece of that, and a small piece of their experience, is honestly just so special," Bucci said. "I mean, the stadium just goes crazy."

During her time at Columbia, Bucci attended some of the University's Homecoming football games, making a day out of it with her sorority and inviting her family to "show them a piece of Columbia school spirit." For Bucci, it was fun to experience the games from both perspectives as a performer and as a spectator.

"Columbia specifically is maybe not a university that's known for its school spirit, so to say. But I think in the moments when it felt like the school had come together and be excited about something, that was always a great thing to be a part of," she said.

Megan Rieger, CC '25, has been cheering Bucci on since the beginning of her journey to becoming a Patriots cheerleader. Rieger, who has been friends with Bucci since their first year at Columbia, saw Bucci audition for the Patriots in the spring and, most recently, saw her perform at the Patriots game on Oct. 18.

Seeing Bucci go from dancing at Baker Athletics Complex to cheerleading at Gillette Stadium, Rieger said, has made her really proud.

"It's really cool to see her do something that she's talked about for so long," Rieger said.

Ashley Myers, CC '25, and Bucci met in their first year and have been "really good friends" ever since. Throughout college, Myers watched Bucci excel in "so many different areas," from taking challenging computer science classes to serving as president of their sorority. Considering Bucci's work ethic, Myers said that Bucci's achievement of becoming an NFL cheerleader comes as no surprise.

"Being friends with Jade, she was so committed to dancing and always making time to take dance classes and teach dance classes all throughout college," Myers said. "It does make sense that she would be able to get to this level of dance."

In addition to being a part-time NFL cheerleader, Bucci also teaches at a dance studio once a week and continues to work in her full-time operations role. Growing up, Bucci said, she felt she had to choose between dance and her more academically oriented career pursuits, but has come to realize that it does not have to be one or the other.

"I'm still able to work my full-time job, where I'm working in tech and operations. I'm still coding. I am still writing queries and doing all those things, but then I can shut my computer off and I go dance for hours on the sidelines in the fields of a renowned organization," Bucci said.

At the end of the day, Bucci believes that closing the door on oneself can lead to regrets later down the line, and therefore encourages others to give everything they aspire to a try—even if that means balancing multiple things at once.

"Looking back, I think five, 10 years from now, I'm gonna be really happy that I was commuting back and forth and spending literally 16 hours a week on the train, going to and from, because I was able to make this happen for myself, and I honestly wouldn't trade it for the world," Bucci said.

taylor.graham
@columbiaspectator.com

From government to groundwork: Angela Simms discusses her debut book 'Fighting for a Foothold'

BY AMOY CHAMBERS
Staff Writer

JACOB WASSERMAN / COLUMBIA DAILY SPECTATOR

CAREER PIVOT | Assistant professor Angela Simms in conversation with Dr. Karida Brown

After serving in the Office of Management and Budget for seven years under the administrations of George W. Bush and Barack Obama, CC '83, on Feb. 24, Angela Simms, assistant professor of sociology and urban studies at Barnard, published her debut book, "Fighting for a Foothold: How Government and Markets Undermine Black Middle-Class Suburbia."

Sitting down in conversation with Dr. Karida Brown, professor of sociology at Emory University, Simms hosted a book salon for "Fighting for a Foothold" at Sulzberger Parlor on Oct. 8. The book analyzes budget and policy development processes in Prince George's County, Maryland, a majority-Black, middle-class suburb.

During the conversation, Simms discussed both her nearly 10-year research and writing process and her career pivot from politics to sociology.

Event organizer Debbie Becher, chair of the Barnard sociology department, explained the importance of the event as a means for sharing Simms' work.

"Dr. Simms is one of our celebrated assistant professors," Becher said. "It is important to us that we provide a forum where the important work that she's done is shared with the public beyond the Barnard gates, with students, with other faculty members and other departments."

To kick off the evening, Simms briefly introduced the novel's overarching purpose: to reveal whether suburban, middle-class Black Americans receive returns equal to those of their white counterparts. For two years, beginning in 2016, Simms collected data by attending budget hearings and resident-led community meetings, interviewing about 60 residents and leaders, and analyzing budget data from Montgomery and Fairfax—two whiter, wealthier counties neighboring Prince George's County—as points of comparison.

When asked why she chose to analyze Prince George's County, Simms highlighted Maryland's geographic and historical importance in the context of racial dynamics. Simms explained that before the abolition of chattel slavery, there were African Americans who owned land. Prince George's County attracted a large Black population, especially during Reconstruction, as it was more affordable than its neighboring counties.

Despite its proximity to Montgomery and Fairfax, Prince George's County has not received the same financial returns. Simms highlighted racial capitalist dynamics, which dictate social and economic value based on race, as the root of this issue. She cited the implementation of policies such as the Tax Reform Initiative by Marylanders. Enacted in the 1970s, TRIM prevents the county from raising the tax rates without a plebiscite, a direct vote from the public. This limits the Black population's ability, particularly in Prince George's County, to access public goods and services.

Brown emphasized solutions Simms presented in her book to combat this issue, such as increasing state-level funding of public goods and services.

"Our role as sociologists, at our best as empiricists, is to tell the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth as a contribution toward the bigger systems-level change that are more inclusive," Simms said. "We can't really move in the right direction unless we know the state on the ground."

To close out the night, Simms read an excerpt from her book. "I hope this book supports the good fight by identifying the right fight, the repudiation of white domination and anti-blackness in all its forms, root and branch, and the pursuit of social systems that usher in shalom, an active, just peace, bringing wholeness to people and communities," she read. "Nothing missing. Nothing broken."

After the discussion, the floor opened up for a brief Q&A. There, Simms discussed the implications of the county's disproportionate financial allocations, while recognizing the social benefits Black families reap from living in a county that "removes you from the white gaze."

Attendee Alaya Walton, GS '28, reflected on what she has learned from taking Simms' course, Race, Ethnicity & Society.

"It's a class that deals with race relations, but specifically intersectionality between race and class," Walton said. "I've actually learned a lot about the model minority, race relations between African Americans, African immigrants, but not only that—Irish American immigrants, Asian American immigrants, and Jewish immigrants."

Even with her current focus on writing and teaching, Simms has not ruled out returning to policy and politics. She emphasized that there is "significant opportunity for change" in those areas.

Simms highlighted the importance of thinking sociohistorically—such as through the lens of racial capitalism—for anyone entering sociology or politics.

"Unless you're really addressing those core issues of exclusion and extraction, you're not actually getting at the root of what is often the inequity that you're trying to address," she said. "Incremental change is not a problem. It's just that it needs to be moving in the direction of actually addressing these causes."

amoy.chambers
@columbiaspectator.com

New York Film Festival review: 'Paper Tiger' turns family melodrama into a heightened thriller

BY STEVEN SONG
Staff Writer

Money is just a piece of paper: spendable, foldable, and flammable. Nowadays, money moves faster than ever. But in 1986 Queens and Brooklyn, where writer-director James Gray's crime thriller "Paper Tiger" unfolds, its weight is enough to pull a family under.

Executive produced by Aidan Kahn, Journalism '24, "Paper Tiger" opened the 64th New York Film Festival on Sept. 25, marking its North American premiere. The film previously competed for the Palme d'Or at the 79th Cannes Film Festival in May.

Following Gray's semi-autobiographical "Armageddon Time," "Paper Tiger" is loosely based on his childhood encounters with New York City's Russian mafia in the 1980s, returning him to the outer-borough crime drama genre that defined his early career with "Little Odessa" and "The Yards."

Following an epigraph by Aeschylus, the film opens in daylight, with a lush field of tall grass swaying under a blue sky. A suburban swimming pool glistens with saturation. Irwin Pearl (Miles Teller), a family-oriented engineer, and his homemaker wife Hester (Scarlett Johansson) chatter about quotidian matters: their two sons' college applications, investments, and maybe wanting a bigger house. Shot on 35mm film by cinematographer Joaquín Baca-Asay, the analog grain roughens the sunlit nostalgia and its bright promise of the American dream.

The darkness arrives at night on an underexposed film stock. The murkiness of the image recalls the suburban underbelly of "Blue Velvet." Gary Pearl (Adam Driver), a divorced former New York Police Department officer who swaggers in tailored suits and drives a Mercedes, coaxes his brother Irwin into a suspicious venture with the Russian mob on the Gowanus Canal.

Hungry for quick cash and readily trusting in Gary, Irwin views the threat as a metaphorical paper tiger and drives his sons to the canal to show off his new project. Here, the family melodrama suddenly turns into a thriller.

As Irwin walks in on mob members dumping oil into the canal, the shot's long focal length turns the night air wavy and unstable, the sequence wobbling with a reflection of the danger he has put his family into. The editing accelerates, cutting between the violence of Irwin's interrogation in chiaroscuro and handheld close-ups of his terrified sons trapped in his car and being threatened by dimly lit mobsters. Even the audio landscape is distorted, with intruding sound effects such as the squeal of a slaughtered pig.

Between the glare of day and the gloom of night, "Paper Tiger" evolves into a film about being unable to see. Hester develops a mysterious disease that gives her double vision. In one scene, staring into the sun briefly blinds her, causing her to crash her car. The decline in her sight mirrors Irwin's figurative blindness because, as a family patriarch, he never sees the costs of his dream and those harmed by his supposedly good intentions.

Hester and Gary pay the price for Irwin's ambition. The film privileges the latter's death with a spectacular shootout sequence. Tall grass under a blue sky surrounds Gary as the camera closes in, and the film reimagines the idyllic opening image with brutal yet restrained bloodshed, as gunshots are swallowed by the roar of airplanes overhead. Gary's death is sublime, set against a pastoral landscape and the machinery of an emerging global economy.

On the other hand, Hester is less developed as a character. Her suffering serves more as a plot device: She learns about her brain tumor in a doctor's office, while her male counterparts participate in exciting shootouts and cinematic action sequences. Though one could argue her agency and strength come from handling her illness alone and actively informing the FBI of Irwin's predicament, the film gives those choices little time and imagination.

At the end of the film, unaware of his wife's tumor and his brother's death, Irwin delivers an encouraging speech to his sons as they head to school. It is unclear whether "Paper Tiger" buys into Irwin's naïve optimism.

As Irwin's flimsy reflection lingers on the window pane, one thing is for sure: His money is still paper and so is the dream it was meant to buy.

"Paper Tiger" will be released in select theaters Nov. 13, preceding its nationwide release on Nov. 20.

steven.song
@columbiaspectator.com

Day in the life: Homecoming

BY JESSICA SINGH
Spectrum Editor

LYNN FU / DEPUTY PHOTO EDITOR

AGENDA | The one stop guide for the once in a year game.

Homecoming is one of those weekends when Columbia students try to do everything at once. Midterm season is in full swing, Halloween and fall break are on the horizon, parents are visiting for Family Weekend, and somehow, we're also expected to care about football. It's basically Halloweekend, except no one knows what to wear, everyone's parents are in town, and the school spirit is largely theoretical. Here's a rundown of my Homecoming.

9:00 a.m. I woke up and remembered I did, indeed, have plans. A rare occurrence for an early Saturday, but I would at least try to get a participation grade in Homecoming.

10:45 a.m. I started getting ready for the day, only to realize I own approximately zero pieces in Columbia blue (Pantone 290, as I now know). You would think by junior year it'd be long enough that some school spirit made its way into my closet, but apparently not.

11:30 a.m. Headed to my friends' pre, which took significantly longer than anticipated. Getting a group of Columbia students out the door on time should qualify as an independent research project.

12:15 p.m. Finally made it to the pre. Everyone was having a great time, and I was enjoying myself enough to momentarily forget that the football game started promptly at 1:30 p.m., and that we were trying to get there on time this year.

1:00 p.m. Wristbands on, my friends and I began the journey to the darty, only to get stuck in a massive crowd of people waiting to get in. After all the effort to leave the pre, I ended up standing in a line with no end in sight.

1:30 p.m. The darty was shut down shortly after. I had barely made it through the crowd before the whole thing was over. All that effort to get out of the dorm was for an event that lasted approximately five minutes. At least I could say I showed up and have cute pictures to prove it.

1:45 p.m. Realized the football game had already started and began the trek to Baker. The train ride takes 25 minutes, which would have been fine if we had actually left when we said we would. Instead, we found ourselves racing against the clock to make it to a game we were already late for.

2:15 p.m. Finally made it to Baker, where Columbia was already down 20 points. Nothing says school spirit like taking the train to watch your team lose by 20 points. I tried to figure out what was happening on the field, cheered when everyone else cheered, and generally hoped no one would ask me to explain the rules.

2:30 p.m. My parents arrived for Family Weekend. Suddenly, I had to pretend I was a functioning adult who knew what was happening on the field and had a reasonably organized life outside of class. I managed to explain approximately none of the football game, but at least we were spending quality time together.

2:35 p.m. We left. After taking the train all the way to Baker, we lasted about 15 minutes. I'm sure the rest of the game was wonderful, but I'll have to take everyone else's word for it.

3:00 p.m. I walked around campus with my parents, showing them where I spend most of my time. I tried to make Columbia sound as academically enriching as possible, while strategically avoiding any mention of how much of my day is spent complaining about being busy.

4:30 p.m. I spent some more time with my family before realizing that Homecoming had somehow become a day-long commitment. It was nice seeing my parents, but balancing Family Weekend and plans with friends felt like trying to maintain two completely separate lives on the same campus.

6:00 p.m. Finally returned to my room to recharge. Between the pre, the darty line, the train ride to Baker, and Family Weekend, I was ready to call it a day. Unfortunately, my friends had other ideas.

7:30 p.m. Heard whispers of Amity plans. I had already spent the day trying to be social, but apparently that wasn't enough. I was dragged into getting ready again, wondering why I had ever thought that staying in for the evening was an option.

9:00 p.m. We made it to Amity, where I ran into friends and people I hadn't seen in a while. Perhaps had a detour or two.

1:00 a.m. Finally made it back to my dorm. I was exhausted, my feet hurt, and I had approximately a week of schoolwork to complete before fall break.

By the end of the day, I had seen my friends, spent time with my parents, attended a football game I barely understood, and been dragged out. Homecoming really does have a little bit of everything, even if I spent most of it running late or trying to figure out what was going on. At least next week is fall break. Maybe by the time I return, I'll finally own something the right color for next year.

jessica.singh
@columbiaspectator.com

Pros and cons of actually going to the Homecoming game

BY REBECCA CISNEROS & DEYI MENG
Columbia Daily Spectator

As the time grows closer to kickoff, and you are still deep in the crowd of your third Homecoming party of the day, you wonder: Should I even bother going to the actual game? You have rallied at an ungodly hour—earlier than you've ever woken up to do real work—and have been socializing the entire morning, using all of your social battery before it's even 1 p.m. Columbia students across generations have grappled with this question. Is it worth going all the way to West 218th Street to watch the Homecoming game? This is the true Columbia tradition, and you may need to weigh the pros and cons on whether you will make an appearance at this year's Homecoming game.

PROS:
SEEING THE STUDENT PERFORMANCES

Football may not be for everyone, but watching some tumbling, dancing, and a pep band may be! Unless you are part of the small population of students who go to the other home games, Homecoming is one of your only options to see these spirit squads during the fall semester. Take advantage of watching the halftime show by bragging to your friends that you used to dance in middle school and can totally tell that one of the girls' feet are flat. Or, watch in awe as the cheer team gleefully stunts across the sidelines—as if the football team isn't down by 18 points.

CUTE PICS

Yes, this is superficial. But the pictures in the stands of Baker Athletics Complex may be the closest we get to showing our school spirit. Why not maximize your perfectly curated Columbia outfit for the Instagram dump? Great natural lighting, matching outfits with your friends, and a picture that isn't taken on the corner of a street will look great on the grid.

SCHOOL SPIRIT

With most athletics facilities more than 100 blocks from campus, the allure of the Big Apple drawing your attention away, and a somewhat lacking sports culture, Homecoming is really the only time of the year you'll ever see the entire school united in a frenzy of spirit besides Bacchanal. There's something oddly comforting about seeing everyone together and cheering our school on, even when we're losing and most people have no idea what's happening.

CONS:
SCHEDULE OF THE DAY

You wake up to your fifth alarm at 8 a.m., running off four hours of sleep, and scramble with your friends to a darty. Before you know it, you're rushing to get to the game on time while standing at the back of a line with a hundred people in front of you. The timing of kickoff at 1:30 p.m., paired with student festivities in the morning and the long journey uptown, often feels inconvenient and frustrating. To make matters worse, Homecoming is often in the middle of midterm season, so can you really afford to watch our school lose to Dartmouth instead of spending your weekend locking in on the "Iliad"?

HAVING TO ACTUALLY WATCH THE GAME

If you don't enjoy watching football, three long hours of sitting and watching men scramble over a ball you can't really see will get old quickly. If you do enjoy football, looking back on Columbia's winning statistics may be a good predictor of whether you will be storming off from the stands at the end of the game. Either way, gambling on spending a beautiful fall day on a 30-minute subway ride and three hours in a stadium may prove to not be worth it.

THE TREK

Arguably the worst part of the Homecoming game is the journey up to Baker. You start by clamoring into a crowded 1 train, filled with a wave of blue and no place to sit. Fellow students sway as they try to sober up as quickly as possible before the motion sickness takes over. After a long 30 minutes, the crowd loads off and you follow it, blindly assuming you are all going the right direction. Somehow, the trip back to campus is almost worse. Everyone flees from the stadium, creating the worst foot traffic back to the 1 train. The steep steps up create a falling hazard that backs up the stampede every few steps. If you can squeeze into a train car, you stand shoulder to shoulder until the sweet release of the 116th subway station.

Homecoming at Columbia is a very different experience than at other schools. It's not just your typical day of fun-filled school spirit, cheering on the football team. Yes, it is a Columbia tradition, gathering many students together for a day of celebration and Lion pride. However, the timing of the event, the long trek to Baker, and the monotony of football may dissuade some individuals from attending. The silver lining to having a flexible student population that isn't totally involved in school spirit is that you can really weigh the pros and cons of going to the game and not feel the fear of missing out on going. Even then, these pros and cons are part of a quintessential Columbia experience you won't want to miss before graduation.

rebecca.cisneros
@columbiaspectator.com

deyi.meng
@columbiaspectator.com

Open when: You have FOMO from Homecoming

BY PARINI RAO
Spectrum Deputy Editor

The anticipated time is finally here: Homecoming. What's supposed to be the most lively and enjoyable day of the year can often leave Columbia students feeling major FOMO.

Who's throwing the best party? Where do I get a ticket? Who should I go with? When's the game? Should I even go to the game? These questions plague the minds of students across Morningside Heights.

The truth is, there is no reason to force yourself into a day that you know you won't appreciate.

Attending Homecoming isn't a requirement to be a part of the Columbia community, and everybody can choose to celebrate—or not celebrate—exactly in the way they prefer. Don't spend your nights stressing that one missed Homecoming will alter the course of your social life.

At a school like Columbia, where school spirit is a rarity, it's natural to want to make the most of the one day a year when people flood the streets in light blue. But what happens when you just don't want to? Maybe football isn't your thing, or maybe you desperately need to lock in for your four midterms the week after. Regardless of the reason, it's completely understandable to not feel the urge to partake in Saturday's activities. Seeing the Instagram stories posted live from a frat's backyard and the aesthetic TikToks all over your For You page can easily make you wish you were attending the same events. Hearing stories from your classmates about their past 18-hour benders on Homecoming might leave you wondering if you should suck it up and rally.

Don't constrain yourself to a full day of plans you won't enjoy solely out of fear. If you're not feeling Homecoming this year, there are plenty of ways you can approach the upcoming weekend. You can take yourself on a solo date to a restaurant you've been wanting to try, actually finish the practice exam you've been staring at for days, or just go about your day like it's any other Saturday. Also, Homecoming doesn't have to be all or nothing. You can spend an hour at a party and then head back to Butler to do some serious work or go far away during the day and eventually make your way to Amity—hopefully celebrating a Homecoming win. You know yourself best, and you shouldn't put yourself in an uncomfortable situation just to avoid missing out.

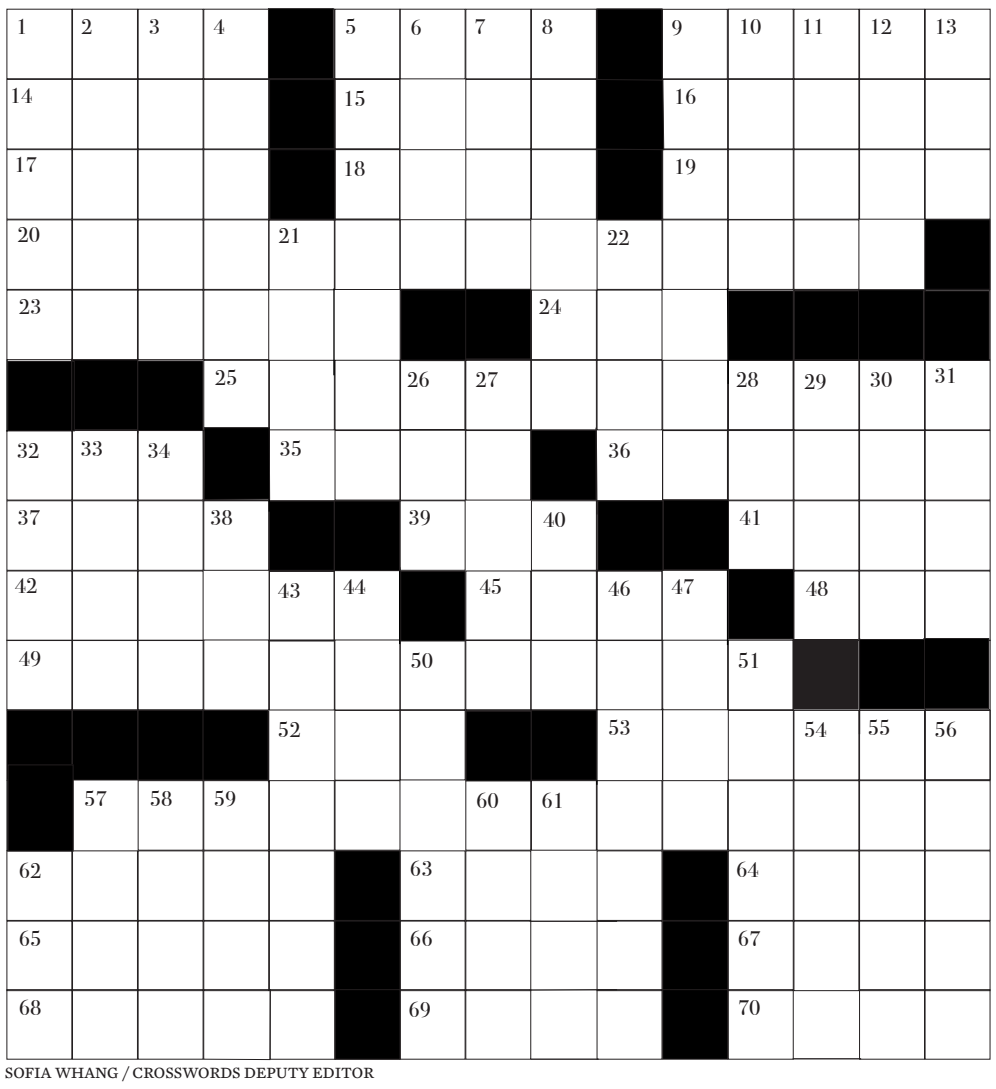
At the same time, don't let your fears about what Homecoming looks like dissuade you from having a great time. If you want to take advantage of a lively campus community, gather friends—or even make new ones on the train ride up to Baker—and enjoy some "entertaining" football and showstopping dance performances. Don't let thoughts about who's doing what and where infest your mind or lead you down a never-ending mental spiral.

There is so much more to Homecoming than you might think or see on social media. At the end of the day, it's a celebration of Columbia and its community. FOMO is natural, but don't let it dictate your life. Go to the darty and trek to Baker if that's what is calling your name, or enjoy a quiet day at the library—where you might actually find a spot for once—crossing off your to-do list. The most important thing is to listen to yourself and understand what you want.

However you choose to spend Oct. 24, we hope you enjoy it!

With school spirit,

Spectrum



SOFIA WHANG / CROSSWORDS DEPUTY EDITOR

Across
1) Songstress Fitzgerald
5) Ashe Stadium org.
9) Pitbull exclamations
14) Woodwind part
15) North of France?
16) Select few
17) Emperor said to have fiddled while Rome burned
18) Our digital research tool
19) Gaze
20) Words to a Columbian on the field
23) Pilfer
24) Alan Partridge's catchphrase
25) Words sung by Columbians
32) Obtain
35) Famous sandwich cookie, available crumbled at JJ's
36) Prima ballerina
37) German cries
39) Hoco festivity before the big game
41) Comes to a close
42) Make space on a bleacher, e.g.
45) Network whose streaming service will air the big game
48) Icon-Knick center-forward
49) Words said to a Columbian who is at a 39-Across
52) Singer Grande, to her friends
53) Hitting the Heights, e.g.?
57) Words said to a Columbian exhausted after a day of Homecoming fun
62) Sierra ___
63) Playing a fifth quarter, e.g. (abbr.)
64) Astounds
65) Attribute
66)
67) Lion ___, app/website for checking CU menus
68) Joseph Sorett and Shih-Fu Chang, e.g.
69) One "coming home" on Homecoming
70) You want to get a good one for Dartmouth v. Columbia

Down
1) Dadaist Max
2) Bloodsucker
3) "___ Malgré Lui," Chabrier opera
4) One who loves
5) Confusing
6) Songs for one
7) 2 + 1
8) "Baruch atah ___"
9) Counterpoint
10) Violist's clef
11) Fibber
12) Raison d'___
13) Observe
21) Milano's order topping
22) Sneaker, e.g.
26) Tie that shows school colors
27) Actress Sophia
28) Caviar
29) Pig's exclamation
30) Actor Alan
31) Take five
32) Noise of surprise
33) Danish shoe brand
34) "___ shalt not..."
38) ESPN stat
40) Clairvoyance
43) Reds
44) Take on
46) Cutting
47) Sisters
50) Conditioning, as leather
51) Promoted
54) "Starman" singer David
55) Sports venue
56) Take it from the top
57) Withered
58) Storm-tracking org.
59) "Come ___," welcome a homecomer might recieve
60) "Are you ___ out?"
61) Mrs. Chaplin
62) Inc., in England

To find the solution to this crossword, scan here.

The Black art of belonging

BY AMIR MASON

MILA PRETOLANI / DEPUTY ILLUSTRATIONS EDITOR

On July 5, 1852, Frederick Douglass stood before an audience in Rochester, New York, and delivered an indictment of America's hypocrisy that would far outlive its occasion: "What to the Slave is the Fourth of July?" Exactly 156 years later, I was born.

Sitting in the immediate wake of our nation's birthday, the speech highlights a sobering truth I've known my whole life as a Black American: The public celebration of the ideals espoused by an institution is wholly different from their actualization. Perhaps naïvely, I never thought that I would confront this same disconnect at Columbia.

Today, I hear echoes of Douglass' speech as we Columbia students seek to reconcile our grievances against the University with our marked identity as its students.

In my time at Columbia, I have come to adopt a shared distaste for the institution. There is no shortage of reasons: Comically abysmal free speech ratings, the University's ongoing gentrification of the surrounding Morningside Heights and West Harlem communities, closed campus gates, presidential turnover, and frustrations with the board of trustees have all drastically shaped students' sentiments about what it means to be a Lion.

We each arrive at Columbia with our own conceptions of what the school ought to be, shaped by the values and experiences we brought with us and the University's mission statements that seem to promise a place for us. But once we become students, we inevitably encounter a Columbia that is not exactly what we imagined. While the grievances may differ, that disillusionment is universal. The more alienated students become from Columbia, the easier it can be to wonder whether criticizing the school requires surrendering our claim to belonging within it.

But criticism does not have to be a rejection of belonging. Criticism can be the way we claim it—an unapologetic declaration that we have a stake in what this place becomes.

Nowhere is this dynamic clearer than in Black America, which has long forged its own forms of belonging in a nation whose freedom was built on the subjugation of Black Americans. The response to institutional hypocrisy has never been passive acceptance. Douglass turned an indictment of America into a vision of its freedom. Black Americans have built a tradition of deliberate recreation, remaking institutions that fail to represent us, inventing new forms of expression, and building collective life on our own terms.

Historically Black colleges and universities were created when white institutions refused to provide us with equal access to education. The Black Power movement built mutual aid and structures of self-determination with clenched fists and luscious afros. Hip-hop rose out of the ashes of the South Bronx fires in the 1970s. Black studies departments took root on campuses, and scholars like Robin Kelley, Sylvia Wynter, and Saidiya Hartman reconfigured Black life as a continuing chronicle of radical world-making. Even ordinary spaces like spades games, cookouts, and family reunions offer sanctuaries of joy and solidarity. When the nation fails to make us feel at home, we have never been without the capacity to build a home for ourselves.

I believe there is something the Columbia community can learn from that praxis of recreation. Just as Langston Hughes declared that "I, too, am America," perhaps we can each say, "I, too, am Columbia."

Columbia, the fortressed institution, the extractive landlord, the opportunist investor, makes decisions many of us oppose. Opposing those decisions makes us no less Columbia than the trustees who sign off on them. To all students who feel disenchanted or frustrated by being here, I urge you to leverage that disappointment into acts of recreation, however small. Start the organization that speaks to a void you see. Write the piece that names a dissonance others have struggled to name. Build the community you wish existed. Create the tradition you wish Columbia had. Within our frustrations lie infinite possibilities.

As we pour our time, conviction, and energy into this work, we must remember that its impact extends beyond the University's response to our demands. The encampments may have failed to achieve divestment. The gates might still be closed. Our demands will often fall on deaf ears.

And yet, claiming a stake in the institutions that shape our lives is never meaningless. In the process, we reclaim agency, cultivate a sense of self, and develop a political consciousness that does not depend on institutional approval. Practically all of the Black Panther Party's Ten-Point Program stands frustratingly unrealized; it nevertheless continues to expand Black America's imagination of what self-sovereignty can—and should—entail. We each have the capacity to do something similar here.

In organizing, you have done the work of recreation and carrying on a tradition of protest at Columbia. Continue. Keep protesting. Keep questioning. Keep expecting more from Columbia, and then take the intentional steps to make those expectations a reality. Love this place enough to criticize it perpetually, be dissatisfied with what it is, and still believe acting on our criticism can make it what we believe it should be.

I, too, am Columbia. You, too, are Columbia.

amir.mason
@columbiaspectator.com

Campus discourse needs an ethics code

BY SPECTATOR EDITORIAL BOARD

As an editorial board of student journalists, we must adhere to an ethical standard that grounds our editorial process. Abiding by the Society of Professional Journalists' code of ethics, we follow the key principle of minimizing harm—most crucially, balancing readers' need for information against prospective harm and acting with compassion toward those who may be impacted by news coverage.

"The 'Cornell 7' is Really about Liberalism," a recent opinion essay published by the Sundial, blatantly violates this principle. In service of "platforming diverse perspectives," the Sundial has leveraged its page to disparage survivors of sexual violence. We stand in opposition to the views expressed by Christina Ma, BC '28, and Nikos Mohammadi, CC '28, which denigrate survivors and promote a culture of skepticism surrounding stories of trauma and sexual violence.

What is more, as others have argued, the Sundial has also fallen short of its foundational journalistic responsibility to provide respectful, well-reasoned discourse for its readership. In turn, it has produced a dangerously insensitive and inaccurate piece.

We find it critical to first examine where, precisely, Ma and Mohammadi's piece falls short in its editorial process. In the de facto constitution posted during the Sundial's founding in 2024, the editorial staff leaders proclaim that they "value good-faith discussion over emotional pleas and personal attacks." In advancing their position, however, they fail in critical ways to uphold even their own editorial standards. They implicitly cast judgment against Doe—for example, by paralleling the alleged assault with "drug-fueled orgies"—in open execution of the "personal attacks" they claim to condemn.

For instance, in describing the sequence of Doe's report of the assault, Ma and Mohammadi write that Doe filed the rape allegation "only once" she had been uninvited from a Halloween party.

However, based on The New York Times' reporting, which Ma and Mohammadi themselves referenced, Doe's decision to report her assault and her disinvitation from the party merely happened to occur in the same month. This clear misconstrual of evidence aims to undermine Doe's credibility as a survivor of sexual violence by insidiously mischaracterizing her as issuing these allegations for ulterior motives.

In another example of an unacceptable breach of editorial ethics, Ma and Mohammadi insinuate that because the Tompkins County district attorney did not press charges when Doe went to the police, Doe's testimony is possibly illegitimate. They fail to mention, though, that the DA has since reopened the case to further investigate. By appealing to a decision of law enforcement that has since been reversed, Ma and Mohammadi build their skepticism of Doe's story on a conflation of a survivor's own truth with its renarrativization by law enforcement.

These misrepresentations are harmful and inaccurate, and they reflect a lack of rigor within the Sundial's editorial process.

SPJ outlines a particularly relevant standard for writing about victims of sex crimes, prescribing the use of "heightened sensitivity" in order to minimize harm to survivors.

Yet, Ma and Mohammadi flippantly discuss the details of a highly sensitive, trauma-laden incident of violence in service of their own argument about the pitfalls of liberal society. By not openly adhering to the SPJ code of ethics, the Sundial cannot ensure that harm is minimized when necessary, such as in this case, allowing for the publication of hateful work on its page.

These editorial deficiencies run counter to the very mission of a platform for discourse. If a core objective of commentary pages is to help readers formulate independent beliefs, then it is their duty to engage with arguments they strongly disagree with, especially if those arguments are held by the students with whom they share their campus. But if the Sundial is going to ask its readers to consider heterodox opinions with both "fervor and decorum," that decorum ought to cut both ways.

We agree with the Sundial that readers should express themselves with op-eds and letters to the editor as opposed to death threats. But we also believe that writers cannot expect to change minds when they reductively portray survivors of sexual violence, as well as the social beliefs or opinions that their readers might very well have.

How can Ma and Mohammadi argue that they are contributing to a productive exchange of ideas if they write without the "decorum" which they themselves preach? How is an opposed reader supposed to engage with Mohammadi and Ma's argument in good faith if the authors aren't making a good-faith effort to reach them?

Spectator's editorial board and the Sundial share a media ecosystem; by providing spaces for the community to share their perspectives and encounter new ones, we function as interlocutory platforms for discourse at Columbia. The argumentative and rhetorical failures made in Ma and Mohammadi's essay are self-destructing forces that degrade the legitimacy of the Sundial as a source of community voices.

It is critical to recognize these failures of editorial work and for us to encourage a fundamental change that ensures that these failures do not go unchecked.

If the Sundial is truly committed to being an outlet for free speech and a diversity of perspectives, it needs to both adhere to its own current editorial standards and further bolster its editorial process by adopting new, ethical ones. It should commit to following the SPJ code of ethics and be guided by principles that equip its editors with the knowledge to nurture discussion in good faith.

opinion
@columbiaspectator.com

#IAmJaneDoe is about healing out loud

BY THANDIWE TAYLOR

Trusting women's stories is not radical, and no amount of conservative framing can make it so. Demanding accountability is not "woke," it is simply just.

In the Sundial's recently published opinion essay, "The 'Cornell Seven' Is Really About Liberalism," Christina Ma, BC '28, and Nikos Mohammadi, CC '28, argue that the social media movement spurred by Jane Doe's case is a result of "America's libertine sexual ethic" that demands "all the sexual freedom and none of the consequences." Accusing the #IAmJaneDoe trend of "infantilizing women," Ma and Mohammadi argue that the movement has mistakenly conflated regret with rape. Criticizing the "gender polarization" caused by Jane Doe's story, Ma and Mohammadi's essay aims to disrupt the so-called "hyper-liberal" echo chamber on campus, where a majority stand in fervent solidarity with Jane Doe.

However, the social movement catalyzed by Jane Doe's story is not, in the words of Ma and Mohammadi, "hysteria" or "unproductive frenzy."

It is a demand for accountability. It is a cry for our legal system to repudiate the clandestinely preserved vestiges of the "boys' club" and to exercise justice. It is an appeal for our administrations to prioritize women's autonomy over rank and prestige. It is about breaking down the silence and stigma surrounding sexual assault by amplifying survivors' stories.

Jane Doe's story is worthy of the national attention it is receiving, but not because it occurred within the gates of an elite Ivy League institution, seemingly elevated from crime or violence, nor because the alleged are among a student body supposedly chosen for their intelligence and excellence of character. Jane Doe's story is important because, like so many sexual assault victims, she was exiled to grapple with her trauma in silence while some of her alleged rapists got away practically scot-free. Several of the perpetrators were assigned reflective essays as punishment, continued with their studies, and at least one even entered the corporate world with no substantial consequences prior to the September lawsuit.

And she is left to pick up the pieces.

#IAmJaneDoe is a viral social media movement that has emerged in opposition to other viral trends aiming to expose Jane Doe's identity. The hashtag has since evolved into a digital haven for women to share their own experiences with sexual assault, resulting institutional failure, and the ostracization and public stigma that too often ensues. This cyber reckoning emphasizes the fact that Jane Doe's story did not occur in isolation. It is a reminder to sexual assault survivors across the country that they are not alone. When the "Cornell Seven" are no longer trending on social media, these women will continue to carry their trauma. #IAmJaneDoe says that they do not have to do so silently.

Ma and Mohammadi diminish this empowering movement to a "social media freak-out," claiming that it has produced dangerous consequences, including "gender-warring" and indiscriminate man-hate. But #IAmJaneDoe is not synonymous with man-hate, nor does it accuse all men of sexual violence. Instead, it forces all of us to contend with the question: Why are we coddling rapists? Why won't educational institutions protect sexual assault victims with the same fervor and resolve with which they defend perpetrators? What makes these men more worthy of their protection? Connections? Bright futures?

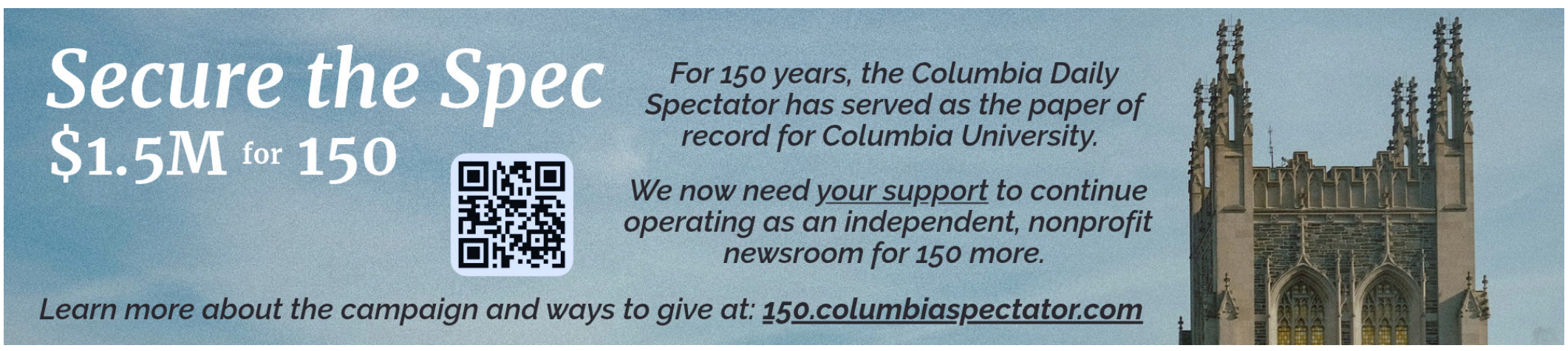
Female students on college campuses are vulnerable—and this is not a diminishing statement. They are vulnerable to men whose brotherhoods keep silent and feign ignorance. They are vulnerable to administrations that are willing to cover up crimes to protect their reputation and to people like Ma and Mohammadi, who redirect the blame to the victim.

However, Ma and Mohammadi's assertion that women cannot expect both sexual freedom and bodily autonomy is lamentably true. We must demand it.

Sexual assault is not a consequence of sexual liberation. It is an evil, degenerate act that exists wherever people do, but is tremendously exacerbated by institutions that are unwilling to condemn it. The herd fraternity mindset is pervasive and has followed privileged men into their positions of power in educational institutions and beyond. #IAmJaneDoe is about reclaiming control of the narrative.

We will not retreat into obscure corners of shame and guilt. We will heal out loud until we achieve justice in our lifetime. We will not be silenced.

thandiwe.taylor
@columbiaspectator.com



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FREE FOR COLLEGE STUDENTS